

# Reading Edition

*The whole play, line by line — and before each line, what it means and what is moving underneath it. Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi*

## HOW TO USE IT

- **Every spoken line carries a note** — the short italic line set just above it, marked by a gold rule. It says what the line is really doing: the intent, the subtext, the move beneath the words.
- **The line itself follows, in full.** Stage directions are set in italic between the speeches, as in the script.
- **Read it straight through** to follow the play with its undertow exposed, or dip into any part — the notes are written to stand on their own.
- The notes read the play through this production's lens: the Father who turns guilt into philosophy, the Step-Daughter who uses truth as a weapon, the Mother as the silent centre of pain, the Son who refuses to be staged, the Manager who becomes the audience's complicity, and the company who stop laughing.

# Act One — The Family

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## PART I — THE REHEARSAL

*The spectators will find the curtain raised and the stage as it usually is during the day time. It will be half dark, and empty, so that from the beginning the public may have the impression of an impromptu performance. Prompter's box and a small table and chair for the manager.*

*Two other small tables and several chairs scattered about as during rehearsals.*

*The **Actors** and **Actresses** of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. They are about to rehearse a Pirandello play: *Mixing it Up*. [Il giuoco delle parti.] Some of the company move off towards their dressing rooms. The **Prompter** who has the "book" under his arm, is waiting for the manager in order to begin the rehearsal.*

*The **Players**, some standing, some sitting, chat in two languages and check their phones. One scrolls yesterday's 24 heures; another mutters her lines under her breath. Somebody, in the wings, is making coffee.*

*Finally, the **Manager** enters with the precise weariness of a man who has been managing the Village Players for too long. He goes to the table prepared for him. His **Secretary** brings him his mail, through which he glances with the expression of one who has never, in his life, received good news from an envelope. The **Prompter** takes his seat, turns on a light, and opens the "book."*

*Exhaustion swinging at the world before the day even starts; the bluster braces him against an institution that brings him nothing but bad news.*

**THE MANAGER** [throwing the morning's letters onto the table]. No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

*Dry and unbothered, already a step ahead of him — one flat fact punctures his theatrics and sets the company's broke, wry tone.*

**PLAYER 2** [she has been at work an hour; not looking up from her clipboard]. It's all three, sir. The same envelope.

*He turns dread into a joke about failure, mocking the room because it mirrors the company he fears they've become.*

**THE MANAGER** [looking round the half-lit room]. And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

*Vanity disguised as wit — he'd rather be cleverly doomed than ignored, grabbing the joke before it can land on him.*

**PLAYER 1** [settling himself, to no one in particular]. Then for once we are perfectly cast.

*He swats the ego and begs for light in one breath, running the room on irritation because it's the only fuel left.*

**THE MANAGER.** Don't be charming, sir — it costs extra, and we can't afford it. [to the Property Man] A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

*The whole production's poverty in four words; stated without complaint, which makes it bite harder.*

**PLAYER 2** [a light comes down on to the stage]. Half light. It's what's left.

*He makes the shortage a punchline — then the mask slips for a single breath: 'God help us' is the fear all the bravado is built to hide.*

**THE MANAGER.** Half light, half a company, half a budget. [a beat] We're ready for Pirandello. [quietly, almost to himself] God help us.

*He claps the fear away and snaps back into command — bravado is the only management he has left.*

**THE MANAGER** [clapping his hands]. Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

*He reaches for the one memory that flatters him, propping his standing on a single ancient success.*

**PLAYER 1** [settling himself]. The public came back for the third act once.

*Two words that quietly call his bluff and dare him to overclaim.*

**PLAYER 2** [not looking up]. For you?

*He doubles down with absurd precision; the distinction means nothing, which is exactly why it lands.*

**PLAYER 1.** During me. There's a difference.

*The intern just does the job, reading the stage description — grounding the chaos in the dull machinery of a real rehearsal.*

**PLAYER 3** [reading the “book”]. “Leo Gala’s house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study.”

*A brisk director's order that assumes resources the company plainly doesn't have.*

**THE MANAGER** [to the Property Man]. Fix up the old red room.

*She answers fantasy with inventory; the correction exposes how little is actually there to work with.*

**PLAYER 2** [noting it down]. The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

*He waves reality away — the director's reflex of willing the impossible into being.*

**THE MANAGER.** Then make it red.

*A flick of contempt, then she fixes it anyway: the joke names the poverty, the action proves she holds the place together.*

**PLAYER 2.** With what, sir? Hope? [a beat] Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

*He reads on, oblivious, delivering the very cue that will detonate Player 1's vanity.*

**PLAYER 3** [reading from the “book”]. “When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook’s cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup...”

*Granted and retracted in one breath — the running gag of a theatre that can't afford its own props.*

**THE MANAGER** [before anyone can object]. Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. [it does not] Mime them.

*The real objection isn't the cap but the humiliation; he is testing whether his dignity can be spared.*

**PLAYER 1** [a small grooming gesture — smoothing the hair before the line]. Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook’s cap?

*He hides behind the text to dodge the fight — the script as shield.*

**THE MANAGER** [annoyed]. It says so there. [pointing to the “book”]

*Wounded pride going public; he invokes fifteen years precisely because he fears they count for nothing here.*

**PLAYER 1.** But it’s ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook’s cap.

*The knife, perfectly dry — she turns his proudest boast into the instrument of his undoing.*

**PLAYER 2** [not looking up from her clipboard]. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

*He stops defending and attacks, recasting humiliation as the actor's sacred task: cruel, funny, and secretly his own creed.*

**THE MANAGER** [rounding on him]. Ridiculous? Of course it’s ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, beat the egg, and become the shell.

*He walks straight into it, vanity unable to resist a cue about himself.*

**PLAYER 1.** The shell?

*He lands the cruelty as a throwaway directing note — 'try not to overplay it' cuts colder than any insult — then slides into the Pirandello lament, fatigue dressed as erudition.*

**THE MANAGER.** Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. [more quietly] And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

*An empty threat reached for out of habit, half-hoping to be talked out of it.*

**PLAYER 1** *[the threat empty; both of them know it]*. I'd sooner resign.

*She denies him the drama; routine deflation that keeps the room from tipping into self-pity.*

**PLAYER 2**. He resigns every Tuesday.

*Capitulation dressed as defiance — he obeys, but insists on being seen to suffer for it.*

**PLAYER 1** *[settling the cook's cap on his head with the dignity of a man mounting the scaffold]*. Let the record show I wear it under protest.

*He grants the gesture and turns back to work; the last clause quietly confesses how thin the illusion has worn.*

**THE MANAGER**. The record is noted. The record is always noted. *[clapping]* Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

*The youngest voice, all fragile hope — a small human request the machine barely registers.*

**PLAYER 3**. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

*Distracted permission; the boy's comfort is a matter of admin, not care.*

**THE MANAGER**. Yes, yes — in, in.

*An innocent question that is secretly the play's whole subject — and, without knowing it, the door he opens for the Characters.*

**PLAYER 3** *[pausing at the box, half to himself]*. Do we ever rehearse anything real?

*A throwaway joke that turns prophecy: the instant he dismisses the real, the real walks in.*

**THE MANAGER**. Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

*The white working lights soften into a warm amber — the "tenuous light" Pirandello specifies for the Six. The **Door-keeper** enters from the stage door carrying the **Boy-chair** — the black coat over its back, the cap on its seat, the satchel by its leg — sets it at the edge of the stage, and advances towards the Manager's table, taking off his braided cap. During this manoeuvre, the four live **Characters** — **Father**, **Mother**, **Step-Daughter**, **Son** — enter, and stop by the door at back of stage. The **Step-Daughter** is already carrying the **Child-bundle**.*

*A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality.*

*This tenuous light will disappear when they come forward towards the actors. They preserve, however, something of the dream lightness in which they seem almost suspended; but this does not detract from the essential reality of their forms and expressions.*

*He who is known as **The Father** is a man of about 50: hair, reddish in colour, thin at the temples; he is not bald, however; thick moustaches, falling over his still fresh mouth, which often opens in an empty and uncertain smile. He is fattish, pale; with an especially wide forehead. He has blue, oval-shaped eyes, very clear and piercing. Wears light trousers and a dark jacket. He is alternatively mellifluous and violent in his manner.*

***The Mother** seems crushed and terrified as if by an intolerable weight of shame and abasement. She is dressed in modest black and wears a thick widow's veil of crêpe. When she lifts this, she reveals a wax-like face. She always keeps her eyes downcast.*

***The Step-Daughter** is dashing, almost impudent, beautiful. She wears mourning too, but with great elegance. She shows contempt for the wretched Boy-chair at the edge of the stage; she shows a lively tenderness for the Child-bundle in her arms.*

***The Son** (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for **The Father**, supercilious and indifferent to **The Mother**. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.*

## PART II — THE INTERRUPTION

*Caught between two identities, the actor inside the doorkeeper cannot quite suppress the dignity that makes the apology feel like a small act of resistance.*

**PLAYER 1** *[cap in hand — Player 1's diction still visible underneath]*. Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

*Reflex authority: he hasn't looked up because nothing outside his rehearsal has earned attention yet.*

**THE MANAGER** *[rudely]*. Eh? What is it?

*The self-correction — timid hedge, then lifted chin — needs the Manager to know the failure was not his fault.*

**PLAYER 1** *[timidly — but not without a small lift of the chin]*. These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

*Two targets, one breath: he scolds the door-keeper and pivots to the strangers without pausing, refusing to let the intrusion cost him a moment of control.*

**THE MANAGER** *[without looking up]*. I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! *[Turning to the Characters.]* Who are you, please? What do you want?

*That hesitant 'actually' and the trailing ellipsis are a pre-emptive apology for a need the Father cannot help having.*

**THE FATHER** *[coming forward a little, followed by the others who seem embarrassed]*. Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

*He repeats the word back because repeating it is the only way to decide whether he really heard it.*

**THE MANAGER** *[half angry, half amazed]*. An author? What author?

*Any author will do — what the Father wants is not a particular writer but the function of authorship: a witness who will hold their story.*

**THE FATHER**. Any author, sir.

*Practical logic used as a door-slam, unaware it also names the Characters' deepest wound: no work exists, no form, for what they carry.*

**THE MANAGER**. But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

*She hijacks the Father's opening move and converts it into a commercial pitch, undercutting him and the theatre's self-importance in a single breath.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[stepping in front of the Father, taking the line]*. So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

*Communal offence-taking bonds the actors together — shared indignation is easier than sitting with the grain of truth inside the taunt.*

**PLAYER 3** *[coming forward from the others]*. Oh — do you hear that?

*The self-correction from 'perfectly' to 'adequately' is the whole wound: vanity punctured in real time, in front of his own company.*

**PLAYER 1** *[stung; it lands because it is half true]*. We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

*Two negotiations running at once — he reaches for the Manager through logic while trying to restrain the Step-Daughter — and both are failing.*

**THE FATHER** *[to Step-Daughter]*. Yes, but if the author isn't here... *[To Manager.]* unless you would be willing...

*'Budget' alongside 'time' demotes the Characters' claim from existential to administrative: a bureaucrat's defence against the uncanny.*

**THE MANAGER**. You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

*His 'for Heaven's sake' is genuine horror at being misread as comic; the weight of the drama must be felt before any argument can begin.*

**THE FATHER**. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

*A dare wrapped in a promise: she knows their story is dangerous and bets his theatrical greed will override his caution.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

*Bundling them with 'our own' mad people accidentally concedes that a theatre is already full of controlled unreality.*

**THE MANAGER.** Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

*He stops theorising and dares the Manager with his own trade: making invented things true is the actor's job — and the Six are already true; they lack only a stage.*

**THE FATHER** *[stepping closer]*. You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

*Applause as self-soothing: the company rescues its collective ego by cheering a speech about immortal works that sidesteps the mirror being held up.*

**THE MANAGER** *[interpreting the rising anger of the **Company**]*. But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards. *[The **Actors**, satisfied, applaud their Manager.]*

*Agreeing so completely becomes an ambush — his embrace of their claim reveals that fictional characters are more honest than the living people in the room.*

**THE FATHER** *[cutting across him]*. Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely. *[The **Actors** look at one another in amazement.]*

*A knife slipped between the Father's ribs: she collapses his grand philosophy into the personal history only she was forced to witness.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[quiet, just to the room]*. Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

*The Father has moved faster than the conversation can follow — a philosopher outpacing a room that still believes it is in charge.*

**THE MANAGER.** But what do you mean? Before, you said...

*He pulls the abstraction back into reach: imagination makes the invisible visible — still pleading his existence, but now in words a listener can hold.*

**THE FATHER.** No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

*A small surrender disguised as pragmatism: he has stopped trying to evict them and is now, despite himself, following the thread.*

**THE MANAGER.** Very well, — but where does all this take us?

*He strips the metaphysics to the bone — not a lecture but a plea: they exist, fully, and have only been denied a place to do it.*

**THE FATHER.** Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

*Feigned dismay is the first crack of genuine engagement: he has begun playing with the idea even as he pretends only to mock it.*

**THE MANAGER** *[with feigned comic dismay]*. So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

*Triumphant but premature — the laughter that follows shows he has won the argument in his own head while losing the room entirely.*

**THE FATHER.** Exactly, and alive as you see! *[**Manager** and **Actors** burst out laughing.]*

*He deploys the Mother's silent, veiled grief as visual evidence, redirecting attention from the absurdity of their arrival to its pathos.*

**THE FATHER** *[hurt]*. I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

*Ordering them out is also an admission: he cannot simply ignore people who have already made ignoring them impossible.*

**THE MANAGER** *[losing patience at last and almost indignant]*. Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! *[To **Property Man**.]* For Heaven's sake, turn them out!

*For the Characters, expulsion is not an inconvenience but an existential threat — his repeated 'no, no' is almost physical resistance.*

**THE FATHER** *[resisting]*. No, no, look here, we...

*Shouting is all he has left; the rational argument has escaped him and only volume remains.*

**THE MANAGER** *[roaring]*. We come here to work, you know.

*Retreating into witty self-regard — the lunch joke, the class marker — rather than admitting the Characters have genuinely unsettled him.*

**PLAYER 1**. One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of, not before lunch, anyway.

*He draws the actors' own professional experience as his evidence: if they can inhabit fictional lives, why can't fictional lives seek bodies to inhabit?*

**THE FATHER** *[determined, coming forward]*. Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" *[Pointing to the Prompter's box.]* which contains us, you refuse to believe...

*'Side-tracked' is the calmest and most devastating word in the scene — it names abandonment as administrative failure, stripping away all sentiment.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[advances towards Manager, eyes level, not smiling]*. Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir; side-tracked however.

*Two names that outlived their makers thrown against his own fate: finished characters live forever; the Six were made alive and then left with nowhere to be.*

**THE FATHER** *[to the Manager]*. Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

*Her 'many times' tells us the Father's grief has become a rehearsed performance for strangers — she has been his unwilling audience all along.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[low, to no one in particular]*. He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

*'Quite all right' is exhausted concession wearing the mask of politeness; he has stopped fighting the philosophy and just wants a practical answer.*

**THE MANAGER**. That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

*Three words that compress the Characters' entire ontological need into something pre-rational — not to tell their story, not to be remembered, simply to exist.*

**THE FATHER**. We want to live.

*Sardonic as it sounds, 'For Eternity?' is his first genuine imaginative engagement: the absurdity has caught him before he can stop it.*

**THE MANAGER**. For Eternity?

*'Only for a moment... in you' is the most intimate request in the play — not an audience but an incarnation, asking actors to become vessels.*

**THE FATHER**. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

*'As if there were room' is professional jealousy dressed as metaphysics — she is protecting her status, not making a philosophical point.*

**PLAYER 2** *[chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1]*. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

*He is losing control of the room and pivots to the Manager as his last practical authority — desperation dressed as organisational energy.*

**THE FATHER**. Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. *[To the Manager.]* But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

*The list of genres ends with honest self-deprecation about the revue, a brief human moment before he retreats behind gatekeeping.*

**THE MANAGER** *[annoyed]*. But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

*Structurally identical to line 48, the 'Exactly!' seizes any opening as confirmation, turning the Manager's dismissal into an unwitting invitation.*

**THE FATHER**. Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

*A book is something he can hold, schedule, control — demanding one exposes the limits of a medium that cannot stage what has no material form.*

**THE MANAGER.** And where is the "book"?

*Asking the actors to trust the living body over the written text is precisely what actors dread and desire in equal measure.*

**THE FATHER.** It is in us! *[The Actors laugh.]* The drama is in us, and we are the drama. We are impatient to play it. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

*She cuts his communal 'our' down to 'his': she does not share the passion — she is its object and its casualty.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[without looking at him]*. His passion. Always the word *passion*.

*The hand held one beat too long on his shoulder is a public staging of the private act that shames them both; she weaponises the touch she cannot take back.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[crossing behind the Father, voice flat]*. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for him. *[Places a deliberate hand on the Father's shoulder, leaves it there one beat too long, withdraws. A single short laugh — no warmth in it.]*

*Fear of exposure, not moral outrage: her cold laugh dismantles the philosophical dignity he has spent the whole scene constructing.*

**THE FATHER** *[angrily]*. Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

*A controlled detonation — she announces her orphan status and immediately punctures its pathos with cabaret, refusing to let anyone pity her.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. Don't worry — it isn't a hymn. *[Sings and then dances Valentine — bright, knowing, the smile a fraction too wide. Not a cabaret turn for its own sake but a provocation thrown by someone two months orphaned and lately for sale, daring the room to enjoy her. The audience should laugh, and then, a beat later, wish they had not.]*

*Entertainment has overridden judgment: the theatre's reflex to spectacle makes them forget, for one unguarded moment, that they were contemptuous.*

**PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3.** Bravo! Well done! Encore!

*His alarm at her sanity is really alarm at his own response — he wants order restored precisely because the song nearly worked on him.*

**THE MANAGER.** Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! *[Turning to the Father in consternation.]* Is she mad?

*Conceding what he cannot explain, the Leading Man lets theatrical metrics slip away and simply admits she has something he cannot measure.*

**PLAYER 1** *[to Player 2, won over]*. She has more stage presence than the second act. I'll say that.

*Madness would be a mercy — the Father refuses it because the safer category would let her stop being right.*

**THE FATHER.** Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

*She seizes the plot's wheel entirely, mapping every turn in advance to leave the Father no corner of the story he can claim.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[to Manager]*. Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here *[Seizing the coat off the chair and shaking it.]* does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. Yes, gentlemen, I'll be off. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me *[Indicating the Father with a horrible wink.]*, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool *[Indicates the Son.]*. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. *[Goes to the Mother and embraces her.]* And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch.*

*Her body speaks before language can: the arms pulling both children close, then falling, say what no sentence of hers has managed.*

**THE MOTHER** *[to the Manager; one arm tightens around the Child-bundle, the other goes toward the Boy-chair as if to keep both of them upright]*. In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[She grows faint and is about to fall.]* Oh God!

*Chivalry deployed as staging — he rushes forward to help and, in the same motion, casts himself as the scene's moral anchor.*

**THE FATHER** *[coming forward to support her as do some of the Actors]*. Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

*Unable to distinguish grief from theatre, the Actors reach for the only category they know and ask whether the collapse is real.*

**PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3.** Is it true? Has she really fainted?

*He calls for the chair and is already directing — the practical crisis and the scene he wants to shape are, for him, the same thing.*

**THE MANAGER.** Quick, a chair! Here! *[One of the Actors brings a chair, the Others proffer assistance. The Mother tries to prevent the Father from lifting the veil which covers her face.]*

*Forcing the Mother's face into public view, he turns her pain into an exhibit that proves his own suffering.*

**THE FATHER.** Look at her! Look at her!

*Her 'no' is not modesty; the veil is the last membrane between a private wound and the spectacle the Father is building around her.*

**THE MOTHER.** No, no; stop it please!

*Lifting the veil, he borrows her body as evidence — the same appropriation that defined the marriage he is now narrating.*

**THE FATHER** *[raising her veil]*. Let them see you!

*Turning to the Manager, she names for the first time exactly what she cannot bear: being made into testimony in someone else's argument.*

**THE MOTHER** *[rising and covering her face with her hands]*. I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

*Reaching for the tidiest domestic category he knows, the Manager hopes 'wife' or 'widow' will restore the authority this family is stripping from him.*

**THE MANAGER** *[dumbfounded]*. I don't understand at all. What is the situation? Is this lady your wife? *[To the Father.]*

*Flat confirmation coated in possessive pride — he claims her still, without noticing that the claim convicts him.*

**THE FATHER.** Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

*The laugh is a defence: the Actors grab the logical absurdity to avoid looking at the emotional reality it floats on top of.*

**THE MANAGER.** But how can she be a widow if you are alive? *[The Actors find relief for their astonishment in a loud laugh.]*

*He needs the room solemn because laughter dissolves the gravity in which his reframing of events can take hold.*

**THE FATHER.** Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

*The cry escapes before she can catch it; the hand at her mouth shows the years of practice she has had doing exactly that.*

**THE MOTHER** *[the cry surprising her — a hand goes to her own mouth, as if to catch it]*. No! No!

*Mourning etiquette deployed as irony — 'most respectable' strips the black clothes of every comfort they were meant to provide.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

*Reclassifying the Mother as a function rather than a person, he erases her desire so that only his philosophical architecture remains standing.*

**THE FATHER.** He isn't here, you see, not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama — powerful sir, I assure you — lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

*At the word children, the Mother's arm closes around the Child-bundle, before any word comes.*

*Breaking her habitual silence, she shifts the grammar from passive to active — 'he gave me' — and for the first time holds the story in her own hands.*

**THE MOTHER.** I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I wanted them? *[To the Company.]* It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

*A reflex of loyalty more than an argument; she is fighting a different battle from the Mother and does not notice the difference.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** It isn't true.

*The denial lands on her body before her mind can form a rebuttal; she echoes it back as a question, still absorbing the blow.*

**THE MOTHER** *[her hand tightens on the Child-bundle without her noticing].* Not true, isn't it?

*Triple repetition is not emphasis — she is persuading herself as much as the room, and the effort shows.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** No, it isn't true, it just isn't true.

*Genuine anguish, not rhetoric: how can a daughter who was not yet born claim authority over what the mother lived and endured.*

**THE MOTHER.** And what can you know about it?

*Her defence of the Father is also self-defence — absolving him keeps the Son's indifference inexcusable and the family wound permanently open.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** It isn't true. Don't believe it. *[To Manager.]* Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. *[Indicates the Son.]* She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because he *[Indicates the Father.]* made her do so.

*One glance upward toward the Son who does not return it, one immediate retreat: the whole arc of maternal failure compressed into a stage direction.*

**THE MOTHER** *[voice tight; eyes still on the floor].* He forced me to it. *[Silence. No one fills it. For the first time she raises her eyes — to the Son. He does not look back. She lowers them again.]* And I call God to witness it. *[To the Manager, still without lifting her head.]* Ask him *[Indicates the Father.]* if it isn't true. *Let him speak.* You *[To the Step-Daughter.]* are not in a position to know anything about it.

*The dead father's tenderness is wielded as a weapon; happiness in that house becomes evidence against the Mother's claim of coercion.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

*Unable to lie about the happiness, she concedes complexity — and the honesty costs her the argument before she can finish the sentence.*

**THE MOTHER.** No, I don't deny it...

*Shaking the empty coat as if the dead man could still testify, she lets grief show through the violence of the gesture.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** He was always full of affection and kindness for you. *[Turning on the Boy-chair, gripping the lapel of the coat as if shaking him by it.]* It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

*Still loyal to the dead man's memory, she draws a careful line between the act of leaving and any passion that might have excused it.*

**THE MOTHER.** Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

*Three words stripped of all philosophical scaffolding — the Father's brevity here is more damning than any speech he has delivered.*

**THE FATHER.** It's true. It was my doing.

*His sentence dies when his eyes reach the Mother; real pain crosses into the theatre space and the appetite for spectacle curdles into something else.*

**PLAYER 1** *[to the Company, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the Mother, and the end of the sentence does not arrive].* What a spectacle. What an absolute... *[He stops. The treat has gone out of it.]*

*Quietly, without irony, she marks the inversion: the professionals have been demoted and the family they cannot perform for has become the show.*

**PLAYER 2** *[lower now].* We are the audience this time.

*One phrase landing in silence does what a full sentence could not — the absence of laughter proves the normal social release has been shut down.*

**PLAYER 3** *[quietly, the pencil not moving].* For once. *[Nobody laughs.]*

*Leaning forward the way an audience member does when they have stopped pretending not to care, the sceptic is becoming a witness against his will.*

**THE MANAGER** *[beginning to get really interested — leaning slightly forward, the way an audience member does when they have started to listen].* Let's hear them out. Listen!

*Pre-emptive ridicule is the Son's only weapon: label the philosophy fast enough and perhaps it will not seduce the room before he can stop it.*

**THE SON.** Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

*Buried inside the attack is the most honest thing he says — 'an expression I found to excuse myself' — and he covers it immediately with contempt.*

**THE FATHER.** You are a cynical imbecile. I've told you so already a hundred times. *[To the **Manager**.]* He tries to make fun of me on account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

*Monotone repetition performs the very thing it accuses; he too uses a word as a wall to keep the Father's reality at arm's length.*

**THE SON** *[without looking up]*. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

*Universalising his failure into everyone's condition, he redistributes guilt until no single person can be held to account for anything specific.*

**THE FATHER.** Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

*Two words cut through the whole edifice: she names remorse as the most self-serving consolation word of all, the one that costs least.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Even remorse. Especially remorse.

*His insistence that he went beyond words is a setup — the hundred francs is the action he substituted for feeling, and it is coming.*

**THE FATHER.** Remorse? No, that isn't true. I've done more than use words to quieten the remorse in me.

*Making the abstraction sordid and exact, she times the detail of the money to destroy whatever sympathy the Father has carefully built.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan. *[A ripple of unease among the **Actors**.]*

*His disgust at her exposure mirrors his own refusal to confront the family's wound; what he calls vile, he also calls too close to home.*

**THE SON** *[to the **Step-Daughter**]*. This is vile.

*With forensic precision she catalogues the shop, forcing the polite euphemism 'robes et manteaux' to carry its real cargo of exploitation and exchange.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

*As the shop is named, the **Mother** draws the Child-bundle up against her and covers its ears with her hand.*

*The unpaid money becomes a moral paradox: the Father is guilty of the intention even though the act was interrupted, desire proven by the attempt.*

**THE SON.** And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

*Compressed into one ironic laugh: bitterness, survivor relief, and self-contempt — a sound that has nowhere respectable to land.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** It was a near thing, though, you know! *[the laugh she means to be ironic does not quite come]*

*She turns the Child's face away before she speaks; the words are addressed inward, a reflex to shield innocence from shame already filling the room.*

**THE MOTHER** *[low, not raised; she turns the Child-bundle's face into her shoulder before she speaks — the words are for the bundle, not the room]*. Shame, my daughter. *[A breath. The **Step-Daughter's** laugh is still in the air.]* Not in front of her.

*Claiming ownership of the shame and inverting it into power, she reconstructs the room so exactly that memory becomes re-enactment and the Father cannot intervene.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I see it. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does. *[Indicating **Father**.]*

*Pirandello plants the Manager here as a surrogate for the audience — confusion on stage to licence confusion in the house.*

**THE MANAGER** *[the audience's confusion, on stage]*. I don't understand this at all.

*Sweating slightly, visibly recovering — the composure is the tell; guilt shows not in the fall but in the effort of repair.*

**THE FATHER** *[he is sweating, very slightly, and trying to keep it from being read; the recovery is visible, that is the trouble]*. Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

*Permission granted with contempt already baked in: she knows exactly what his explanation will do and what it will quietly leave out.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

*He compresses his whole defence into an alibi: language itself betrays him, so every attempt to explain the wound only deepens the charge against him.*

**THE FATHER**. Words are the whole trouble. I say one thing, she hears another. I try to explain myself — and the explanation becomes another crime.

*Three words outweigh all his speeches; the simplest statement is the one that has been waiting longest in the room to be said.*

**THE MOTHER** *[not loud, not an accusation — the plain fact, set down in the middle of the room]*. But you drove me away. *[A beat. It lands before he can talk over it.]*

*He needs the witnesses to hear the denial more than he needs the Mother to believe it; disbelief is directed outward, not inward.*

**THE FATHER**. Do you hear her? I drove her away! She believes I really sent her away.

*'A poor woman, nothing' — she was married into disappearance long before she was sent away, and names it without bitterness.*

**THE MOTHER** *[looking at the floor between them]*. You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir *[To Manager.]* — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

*The spread arms are the gesture of a man who has always considered himself misunderstood — but the silence that follows shows no one is rushing to prove him right.*

**THE FATHER**. — it was for your humility that I married you. I loved this simplicity in you. *[He stops when he sees she makes signs to contradict him, opens his arms wide — the gesture of a man who has, for twenty years, been unable to be heard inside his own house.]* You see — she denies it. She cannot hear me. *[Touches his forehead. A short silence; nobody comes to his aid.]* She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

*Away from feelings and toward consequence: she measures intelligence by the damage it has done, not the depth at which it operates.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

*A last philosophical escape hatch — and the stage direction that immediately follows, vanity breaking into the room, punctures it before it closes.*

**THE FATHER**. If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do? *[At this point the **Leading Lady** who is biting her lips with rage at seeing the **Leading Man** flirting with the **Step-Daughter**, comes forward and says to the **Manager**.]*

*Impatience turns professional: she mocks the intrusion to yank the room back toward the work she was actually hired to do.*

**PLAYER 2**. Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

*Caught between duty and a fascination he won't yet name, he buys time with the most non-committal sentence available.*

**THE MANAGER**. Of course, of course; but let's hear them out.

*'Educational' is the Ingénue's polite demotion — she files the Characters under specimen rather than competition.*

**PLAYER 1** *[the falsetto is half a beat too low; Player 1's voice is showing]*. Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

*Rent against philosophy: she plants her flag on the side of labour and recruits Leading Man with a glance.*

**PLAYER 2**. Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. *[Casts a glance at **Leading Man**.]*

*Seating himself while issuing the command, he accepts — provisionally — the role of audience.*

**THE MANAGER** [to **Father**]. You must please explain yourself quite clearly. [Sits down.]

*Generous patron comes first in the Father's account; the engineering of the arrangement comes later, buried under sympathy.*

**THE FATHER.** Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor man, a clerk, a secretary of mine, full of devotion, who became friends with her. [Indicating the **Mother**.] They understood each other, kindred souls in fact, without the slightest suspicion of evil between them. They were incapable even of thinking of it.

*Four words and the philanthropy collapses — she names the desire he has been wrapping in euphemism.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** So he thought of it — for them!

*A man who cannot tolerate intimacy that excludes him: the 'constant rage' at silent glances is control dressed as suffering.*

**THE FATHER.** That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess, at the same time. Things had reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their making a silent appeal to each other with their eyes. I could see them silently asking each other how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And this alone, believe me, was enough to keep me in a constant rage — to exasperate me beyond measure.

*The obvious question is a trap the Father has been waiting for — it unlocks the next, more damaging, revelation.*

**THE MANAGER.** And why didn't you send him away then — this secretary of yours?

*Pity and contempt occupy the same word: he pictures the Mother as a pet, not a person.*

**THE FATHER.** Precisely what I did, sir. And then I had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master. Like an animal one has taken in out of pity.

*Not agreement — the sound of someone enduring a version of her own story that has been taken from her.*

**THE MOTHER.** Ah yes...

*He turns to her for corroboration, weaponising her silence and forcing her into the impossible position of witness against herself.*

**THE FATHER** [suddenly turning to the **Mother**]. It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

*She corrects the sequence — the son was taken first, making every subsequent act of 'liberation' a compounded dispossession.*

**THE MOTHER.** He took my son away from me first of all.

*Country air and health name the child's benefit while burying the Mother's loss inside a middle-class rationalisation.*

**THE FATHER.** But not from cruelty. I did it so that he should grow up healthy and strong by living in the country.

*Two words and a pointed finger: the Son's visible coldness is the evidence already in the room.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [pointing at him, no smile]. As one can see.

*Wet nurse, weak mother, moral aspirations — he can only confess inside an excuse, every admission cushioned by the next.*

**THE FATHER** [quickly]. Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, as his mother did not seem strong enough. That, sir, was the reason I married her. Unpleasant — but how can it be helped? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

*A stage director's instinct cuts through: story is what the theatre can use, not philosophy.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

*'Regular customer' lands as a court verdict, converting abstract moral aspiration into a transaction with a price and an address.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

*The theatre professional senses he has wandered into something that cannot be rehearsed away — and shifts in his seat.*

**PLAYER 1** [shifting in his seat, eyes down — quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]. — These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

*'Fool!' is self-directed anger redirected outward; the elaborate speech that follows tries to turn contradiction into virtue.*

**THE FATHER** *[a hand goes to his brow, almost despite himself]*. Fool! That is the proof that I am a man. This seeming contradiction, gentlemen, is the strongest proof that I stand here a live man before you. It is precisely this incongruity in my nature that has made me suffer what I have suffered. I couldn't live beside that woman *[Indicating the Mother.]* any longer; not so much for the boredom she inspired in me, as for the pity I felt for her.

*Flat repetition of 'He calls it pity' is deliberate deadpan — she lets the word echo in the room until it rots.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[flat, into the room]*. He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

*The dash is the hinge: she cannot finish because the act of being turned out still has no proper name for her.*

**THE MOTHER**. And so he turned me out —.

*'Well provided for' is a bookkeeper's phrase hiding a transaction — he paid her off and calls the currency freedom.*

**THE FATHER**. — well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

*Three words strip the Father's altruism to its skeleton: the liberation was always primarily his.*

**THE MOTHER**. And to free himself.

*Crossed arms betray the self-consciousness of a man composing himself mid-lie as he reframes surveillance of her new family as tenderness.*

**THE FATHER**. Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. *[Beat.]* But great evil has come of it. I meant well, sir. I did it for her sake more than for mine. *[Crosses his arms; then turns to the Mother.]* Did I ever lose sight of you, until that other man carried you off to another town? I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around her. *[Points to the Step-Daughter.]*

*She delivers the memory to the room, not to the Father — the audience becomes the jury, not him.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[the cleverness drops — just the child she was]*. Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*.

*'Infamous' is the word of a man afraid the image is true rather than certain it is false.*

**THE FATHER**. This is infamous, shameful!

*Quiet 'Why?' is the cruelest possible response — she refuses him even the dignity of a denial to push against.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. No. Why?

*'Dazed fly' exposes the surveillance: the emptiness he describes is a vacuum he was responsible for creating, and he calls being drawn back to it tenderness.*

**THE FATHER**. Infamous! infamous! After she *[Indicating the Mother.]* went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. And then — strange but true — I was driven, by curiosity at first and then by some tender sentiment, toward her family, which had come into being through my will. The thought of her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

*Even the cynics are drawn in — the mock-scholarly notepad is the company losing its ironic distance against its professional will.*

**PLAYER 2** *[the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad]*. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

*Forensic calm is more damning than outrage: each detail — hat, bouquet, straw — is a piece of evidence she has long catalogued.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Yes, yes. True. He used to follow me in the street. I told my mother, who guessed at once. *[The Mother agrees with a nod.]* She wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again, with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

*'Discursive' is the dramaturg's complaint: the story is real but shapeless, and the theatre needs a scene, not a deposition.*

**THE MANAGER**. A bit discursive this, you know!

*Contempt for the Father's self-dramatisation and for the entire theatrical frame that flatters everyone's pain into narrative.*

**THE SON** [turning his face away from the **Father**]. Literature. Literature.

*Life, passion — his deepest vanity surfaces: suffering too real for fiction, even as he performs it for the room.*

**THE FATHER.** Literature indeed! This is life, this is passion!

*'It won't act' is the theatre's verdict on raw experience: what cannot be shaped for an audience has no place on stage.*

**THE MANAGER.** It may be, but it won't act.

*He pre-emptively edits his own story for stagability, deciding which parts — the stalking, the gifts — to suppress.*

**THE FATHER.** I agree. This is only the part leading up. I don't suggest this should be staged. She [Pointing to the **Step-Daughter**.], as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

*Completing his sentence is an act of possession — she will not let him control even the grammar of her own transformation.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** — and the skirt down past the knee!

*A connoisseur's excitement about his own catastrophe: guilt turned into a selling point for the drama he is pitching.*

**THE FATHER.** The drama is coming now, sir; something new, complex, most interesting.

*The biological father's death is stated as fact, not grief — it is simply the door through which disaster entered.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** As soon as my father died...

*The pointing gesture 'immediately regretted' catches his habit of using the Mother as exhibit before he can stop himself.*

**THE FATHER.** — there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. [A small pointing gesture toward the **Mother**, immediately regretted.] She can barely write her own name; but she could at least have had her daughter write — to tell me that they were in need.

*Not rhetorical — the genuine bewilderment of a woman for whom his 'sentiment' was always invisible behind his actions.*

**THE MOTHER.** And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him?

*He converts the Mother's incomprehension into her failure, as if emotional literacy were a duty she breached rather than a code he kept secret.*

**THE FATHER.** That is exactly your mistake, never to have guessed any of my sentiments.

*Her unfinished sentence holds the entire weight of the years he is glossing — time and event are her evidence, not his feeling.*

**THE MOTHER.** After so many years apart, and all that had happened...

*'Naturally' arrives before he can stop it and does more damage than the rest of the speech: it confesses that his interest was always conditional.*

**THE FATHER.** Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? After he had found some job, I could find no trace of them — and, [the word arrives before he can stop it] naturally, my interest dwindled. [The room hears the word "naturally". He does not look up.] But the drama culminated, unforeseen, on their return — when I was driven by the loneliness that still had its grip on me. Ah, what wretchedness is in the man who is alone, and too proud for the shabby, easy comforts. Not old enough to do without company. Not young enough to seek it without shame. It is worse than misery. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. [A beat. He has to swallow.] One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us. That's all.

*The whispered rudeness is the company's id speaking — the speech has stripped decorum and what remains is the audience's unspeakable private reaction.*

**PLAYER 1** [under his breath, to Player 3]. I have several questions. None of them are polite.

*Nine words answer his whole theory of secret shame: the courage he claims is impunity dressed as honesty.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** All appear to have the courage to do them though.

*His theory of mutual blindness is an absolution factory — social hypocrisy becomes a system that makes him merely its most honest member.*

**THE FATHER.** Yes, but in secret. Let a man only speak them out, and folks at once label him a cynic. But he is like all the others — he only admits, with the light of intelligence, the plain shame in all of us that most men prefer to close their eyes upon. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have.*

*She names what his system cannot accommodate: the woman who no longer needs to look away, who sees clearly and is disgusted.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, all this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then seeks to excuse him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer aspiration, every sense of duty, modesty, shame — then nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

*'Discussion' is his word for what belongs in the rehearsal room — he wants the wound itself, not the wound's theory.*

**THE MANAGER.** Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

*The sack metaphor is his most polished evasion — he aestheticises a request for sympathy into a theory of knowledge.*

**THE FATHER.** Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you have to put into it the reason and sentiment which have caused it to exist. I couldn't possibly know that after his death they had decided to come back here, that they were in misery, and that she [*Pointing to the **Mother.***] had gone to work as a seamstress, in a shop of Madame Pace's kind.

*A guided tour of the apparatus of respectable exploitation — she names the machine before she names what it processed.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** A real high-class modiste, gentlemen. In appearance she dresses the leaders of the best society — but she arranges matters so those elegant ladies serve her purpose, and the rest of us — well, the rest of us serve a rather different purpose.

*An appeal to credibility from the least credible witness to her own victimisation.*

**THE MOTHER.** You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

*Told with cold precision — she has narrated the torn-dress scheme to herself many times, assembling the proof that the trap was designed.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Poor Mother! Do you know, sir, what that woman did when I brought her back the work my mother had finished? She would point out to me that I had torn one of my dresses, and she would give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid for it, always I; while this poor creature here believed she was sacrificing herself for me and these two children here, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

*Steering toward the scene, he has accepted his role as dramaturg of a real catastrophe.*

**THE MANAGER.** And one day you met there...

*'Superb!' is pure theatrical aggression — she dares the Manager to stage the scene that will destroy the Father's remaining dignity.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

*Fixing the timeline before the Step-Daughter can: 'then' arrives in place of any moral word.*

**THE FATHER.** She, the Mother arrived just then...

*'Almost in time' is the blade: it tells the room that 'in time' is the Father's revision, not the truth.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Almost in time.

*Repeating 'in time' twice is a man trying to win a verdict by sheer repetition; 'I cannot look her in the face' is the only honest thing he says.*

**THE FATHER** [*crying out*]. No — in time. *In time.* Fortunately I recognized her... in time. And I took them back home with me to my house. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

*Contempt sharpens into refusal: she won't play modest young miss after Madame Pace's room, and no amount of the Father's moral vocabulary can make her.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

*His defence reduced to its nerve — do not let one moment be the whole of me — even as the room, the table, the envelope make that moment impossible to outrun.*

**THE FATHER.** She wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

*Forensic and final: she answers his plea with the one fact it cannot survive — nobody made him walk into that shop.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*flat*]. You walked into that room by yourself.

*A quiet puncture: naming it a confession collapses the Father's elaborate self-defence into the one word he spent the whole speech avoiding.*

**PLAYER 2.** Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

*Stillness as refusal — his body simply won't enter the scene, the only sovereignty left to a son who has been handed a role he never agreed to play.*

**THE SON** [*hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Leave me alone. I don't come into this.

*Not a question but a demand: the Father needs the Son onstage to complete his tableau and cannot accept that a character might simply walk off the stage.*

**THE FATHER.** What? You don't come into this?

*Being "mixed up" with them feels contaminating; the Son is fighting to keep the family story from adhering to him like a stain he can never wash off.*

**THE SON.** I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

*Class irony turned to weapon: she calls herself vulgar to expose his pretension, then conscripts the Manager as witness to a shaming the Son cannot sidestep.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. You may have noticed, Mr. Manager, that I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

*One syllable of disbelief that is not innocence — it's an instinct to contest the record before it hardens into fact against him.*

**THE SON** [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

*An indictment reframed as domestic history: "mistress of the house" reclaims a dignity the Son's cold contempt had already stripped from her family.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** You — you! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

*Switching from accused to narrator, he repaints the Step-Daughter as threatening and mercenary — a defence against the charge of cruelty that makes him sound crueller.*

**THE SON.** It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. One day, gentlemen, a young woman of impudent bearing arrives at my home, asking for my father. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there — and asks him for money, in a way that lets one suppose he *must* give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

*Calm, almost proud admission; acknowledging the debt to the Mother positions him as honourable and quietly blunts the Son's implicit charge of exploitation.*

**THE FATHER.** But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

*"Unrealised" becomes both self-diagnosis and escape hatch: name yourself incomplete and no complete action — no complete guilt — can ever be pinned to you.*

**THE SON.** How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

*He senses the philosophical leverage in the Son's self-erasure and starts to turn it back on him — but the trap closes before he can finish the sentence.*

**THE FATHER.** What? It is just because you are so that...

*Absent fathering forfeits the right to define a child; the counter-attack shifts the ground from what he is to who on earth has the authority to say so.*

**THE SON.** How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me?

*The cold cracks for one line — he names the part forced on him: the family needs an innocent to blame, and he is it.*

**THE SON** [*the one time the cold cracks*]. You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

*The Mother's tears are pointed at the Manager like an exhibit; genuine pain is being stage-managed in front of a stage manager, and nobody blinks.*

**THE FATHER.** I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... [*Pointing out the **Mother** to the **Manager**.*] See, she's crying!

*Three words of flat contempt; by refusing the Mother's grief as weakness, she shows how completely she has shut herself to anything that resembles softness.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*without looking at the **Mother***]. Like a fool.

*The Boy's silence becomes ammunition: the Father turns a mute child's suffering into dramatic argument, weaponising his pain to pressure the Son.*

**THE FATHER** [*indicating Step-Daughter*]. She can't stand him, you know. [*Then referring again to the Son.*] He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. [*In confidence.*] The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

*Brutal pragmatism laid bare — inconvenient bodies, especially children's, are simply cut; the stage keeps only what it can use.*

**THE MANAGER.** Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

*He stops explaining and lets the ending haunt — the children gone, a family left in one house unable to belong to one another, the wound the whole play will circle.*

**THE FATHER.** The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.

### PART III — THE BARGAIN

*Caught despising his own curiosity — he resents being interested, which is the surest sign the bargain is already working on him.*

**THE MANAGER.** Damn it... there is something in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me.

*She steps forward to plant a flag: the drama lives in her, not the Father, and she wants that acknowledged before any deal is struck.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*coming forward*]. When you've got a character like me.

*Panic beneath the snap — her bluntness could wreck the careful seduction he has been building, and he cannot afford it.*

**THE FATHER** [*shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the **Manager***]. You be quiet!

*Intrigued despite himself and bristling at being intrigued — he covers the pull of the idea with an accusation, as if their nerve were the problem, not his own appetite.*

**THE MANAGER** *[reflecting]*. It's new... hem... yes... You've got a nerve, though — to come here and fling it at me like this.

*Destiny, not desperation — he reaches for ontology to give the intrusion dignity and deflect the whiff of a pitch.*

**THE FATHER.** You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

*Professional hierarchy deployed as a defensive wall: label them amateurs and the uncanny becomes merely impertinent.*

**THE MANAGER.** Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

*He starts the distinction that will expose the Manager's comfortable categories, then trails off, sensing philosophy is unwelcome here.*

**THE FATHER.** No. I say born for the stage, because...

*Flattery as interruption — the Manager buries the metaphysics under bonhomie before it can do real damage to the transaction.*

**THE MANAGER.** Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

*He claims a seriousness above mere acting — not pretending but living what life assigned — turning the Manager's jibe into the premise of the bargain.*

**THE FATHER.** No, sir. We do not act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in.

*Passing the creative burden to an absent author is a bid to stay administrative, clean-handed, and safely on the other side of the footlights.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

*He names the bargain exactly: the Manager is asked not to create them but to shape them — flattery and trap in one, handing the director ownership of their pain.*

**THE FATHER.** No, no. Look here! You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.

*Genuine bewilderment, but short — the question already contains the hinge on which assent will turn.*

**THE MANAGER.** I? What are you talking about?

*Naked insistence strips the polite request away; he wants the Manager to feel chosen, even commanded.*

**THE FATHER.** Yes, you, you! Why not?

*A bureaucratic objection, not a moral one — he defines himself by job title, which is exactly the gap the Father will walk through.*

**THE MANAGER.** Because I have never been an author: that's why.

*The seduction at its most elegant — authorship reduced to listening, so the Manager can tell himself he only transcribes, never stages a family's ruin.*

**THE FATHER.** Then become one now — not by inventing, sir, but by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down.

*Two words too brief to be conviction; the silence around them is already filling with capitulation.*

**THE MANAGER.** It won't do.

*Present tense is the trap — 'live,' not 'perform,' collapses the distance between their wound and his product.*

**THE FATHER.** What? When you see us live our drama...

*Craft invoked as a boundary: he can feel the pull but needs the alibi of a missing writer before he can say yes.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

*Stenography, not authorship — strip the Manager of all creative risk and acceptance becomes frictionless.*

**THE FATHER.** No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

*Almost, bit of an idea, might: the hedged language is a professional rationalising surrender as experiment, wanting permission from his own words.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

*He moves to demonstration immediately, knowing that once a scene is witnessed it cannot be unseen or unfelt.*

**THE FATHER.** Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

*The moral hinge: he knows he should refuse and wants it anyway — appetite overriding conscience, a director seduced by someone else's pain.*

**THE MANAGER** *[he is hooked, in spite of himself; the schedule he came in trying to defend is no longer in his mind]*. God help me, it tempts me. I ought to throw you out — and instead I want to see the first scene. Come to my office. We'll see what can be done.

*She will not let the Father own the story — cold and exact, a warning that his version is a performance she means to break.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[level]*. Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.

*A question that is really an order — he ensures the whole wound enters the room where the deal will be made.*

**THE FATHER.** There's no doubt about it. They *[Indicating the Characters.]* had better come with us too, hadn't they?

*His repeated 'come on' and the punctuality instruction show he has already mentally recast himself as director of their reality.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the Actors.]* Be punctual, please! *[Manager and the Six Characters cross the stage and go off. The other Actors remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

*Wounded vanity speaks first; 'furniture' is the word that gives away his fear — professional identity made irrelevant in seconds.*

**PLAYER 1.** Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

*A soft correction that signals unease more than insight; he senses something wrong but cannot yet name what it is.*

**PLAYER 3.** They are not ordinary strangers.

*What unsettles everyone gets its sharpest form here: these visitors arrived with catastrophe pre-formed, bypassing every normal theatrical process.*

**PLAYER 2.** No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

*Bitter sarcasm about the timeline collapses artistic ambition into a scheduling grievance; his real concern is not art but hours.*

**PLAYER 1.** And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

*Curiosity begins to crack the professional resentment; his tentative observation is the first fracture in the company's united front.*

**PLAYER 3.** Perhaps there is a play.

*Labour economics as self-protection — reduce everything to wages and the Characters' pain need not be felt at all.*

**PLAYER 2.** There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

*Two layers visible at once — cap in hand, Leading Man posture leaking through — the actor unable to fully disappear into a minor role.*

**PLAYER 1 (AS DOOR-KEEPER)** *[the cap forgotten in his hand; Player 1's posture leaking through the doorman's apology]*. I only let them in.

*A crisp moral verdict dressed as a practical dismissal; she turns his admission into complicity in whatever comes next.*

**PLAYER 2.** That is not a defence.

*Their air of inevitability was so complete it overrode every professional instinct; the excuse is chilling precisely because it is true.*

**PLAYER 1.** They looked expected.

*Comic in timing, serious in implication — the boundary between performance and record has dissolved and nobody knows which side they stand on.*

**PLAYER 3.** Am I taking this down?

▮ *Treating it as potential evidence is the moment the company stops watching a curiosity and starts fearing they are inside a consequence.*

**PLAYER 2.** Take everything down. It may be evidence.

*Thus talking, the **Actors** leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.*

# Act Two — The Theatre

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## PART I — THE SETUP

*The stage call-bells ring to warn the company that the play is about to begin again.*

*The Step-Daughter comes out of the Manager's office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —*

*She seizes the stage in the same breath she refuses it — stepping forward with the children while claiming she wants no part of the mess.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the Child-bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the Boy-chair to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

*The stage darkens around her. The shower — a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, slow and child-haunted, beneath what follows. She kneels with the Child-bundle held against her chest, the Boy-chair leaning a short pace away. She speaks the next monologue live, alone in the column of light.*

*Beneath the lullaby, a forensic inventory: she already knows the revolver is in that pocket, and her tenderness is a farewell she cannot say plainly.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[bends over the Child-bundle and takes the cloth between her hands as if it were a small face].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to the Child.]* Don't be afraid, Rosetta. It's only a stage — a place where they make false things and call them true. A garden, a fountain — just suppose it, here, in the middle. All make-believe, my pet; and better so, for a real one would only frighten you. *[A pang.]* You who are real, baby dear — who really played by a real fountain, green and beautiful, with the little ducks. *[She sets the Child-bundle down carefully and reaches for the coat on the Boy-chair, taking it by the sleeve as if by the boy's arm.]* And you — what have you got there? *[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver, holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket.]* Ah. Where did you get this? Idiot. If I had been in your place — instead of killing myself, I'd have shot one of those two. Or both. Father and son.

*The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds on her for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair. The Boy and the Child are silent objects again.*

*Cheerful efficiency is how he erases her — 'it's all fixed up' quietly abolishes the question of what she wants.*

**THE FATHER.** Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

*Excitement has replaced neutrality; he is no longer a referee but a co-conspirator, pulling her toward the office he once presided over.*

**THE MANAGER** *[also excited].* If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

*Her sarcasm lands and then dissolves — she follows anyway, trapped inside the story she would most like to destroy.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The Father, Manager and Step-Daughter go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, The Son followed by The Mother, comes out.]*

*Contempt is the only wall he has left; 'I can't even get away' admits the wall is not working.*

**THE SON** *[looking at the three entering office].* Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away. *[The Mother attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the Child-bundle into her lap and draws the Boy-chair close beside her. She casts a glance again at the Son, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

*She genuinely believes that suffering in silence should excuse others from watching — the Son's refusal to look away devastates her.*

**THE MOTHER.** Isn't my punishment the worst of all? *[Then seeing from the Son's manner that he will not bother himself about her.]* My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

*The Mother rises. She takes one step toward the Son, the Child-bundle still in her arms.*

*Two syllables, no more — she reaches for him knowing the hand will not be taken.*

**THE MOTHER** *[barely]*. My son —

*The Son turns away before the word is finished. She stops where she is; the unfinished word stays in the air between them. After a moment she sits again, and holds the Child-bundle a little lower, as though it had grown heavier in her arms.*

*By dragging the parents' private life into the open, he dismantles the very idealization that had protected him from his own shame.*

**THE SON** *[half to himself, meaning the Mother to hear — eyes on the floor]*. And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. *[Pauses.]* He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about my case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

*Pencil down: the story has crossed into territory that a professional record cannot ethically follow.*

**PLAYER 3** *[very quietly, the pencil gone still in their hand]*. *Mon Dieu.* I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

*The Mother hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the Actors and Stage Manager return, followed by the Property Man, and the Prompter. At the same moment, The Manager comes out of his office, accompanied by the Father and the Step-Daughter.*

*A director's voice reasserting itself over material that has stopped behaving like material.*

**THE MANAGER** *[trying to take the rehearsal back, his director's voice returning]*. Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

*Even in a walk-on reply, Leading Man habit survives — vanity finds a way to color two words.*

**PLAYER 1** *[two words; somehow still managing to deliver them as a Leading Man]*. Yes, sir.

*A domestic space reduced to a lighting problem and a door: the Manager's shorthand for the room where the Step-Daughter was sold.*

**THE MANAGER.** Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

*The Machinist runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while The Manager talks with the Stage Manager, the Property Man, and the Prompter on matters of detail.*

*The sofa question is not casual — the right furniture is a piece of evidence, and he does not yet know that.*

**THE MANAGER** *[to Property Man]*. Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

*Institutional inertia delivered with flat certainty: the theatre stocks the sofa it has always had, indifferent to what any particular scene actually requires.*

**PLAYER 2** *[the Property Man's voice, flat and certain]*. There's the green one. It is the sofa we have. It has always been the sofa we have.

*Yellow with flowers is not a preference but a forensic fact — the exact sofa is the only one that holds her memory of that afternoon.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

*'It doesn't matter' is the production's original sin: convenience chosen over fidelity, and she will not forget it.*

**THE MANAGER.** It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

*Wrong props will make her truth look invented; 'most important' is a fight to keep reality from being swallowed by approximation.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Doesn't matter? It's most important!

*Silencing her to demand the shop window shows he understands the scene's geography even while refusing to understand her.*

**THE MANAGER.** We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. *[To **Property Man**.]* See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

*Named with a survivor's precision — the mahogany table and pale blue envelope are relics she has never once stopped seeing.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

*Gilt for mahogany: another small substitution that cheapens the moral economy of the room without the Manager registering the difference.*

**PLAYER 2** *[to **Manager**].* There's that little gilt one.

*Breezy acceptance where careful attention was owed — he is dressing a set rather than reconstructing what happened.*

**THE MANAGER.** That'll do fine.

*Without the screen the scene cannot be staged as she lived it — half-hidden, half-visible is not a staging preference but the truth of the memory.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

*'Any amount of them' inadvertently mocks the scene's singularity: the theatre is generously stocked in screens for shame.*

**PLAYER 2.** That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

*Asking about clothes pegs is the moment he grasps the room's function — and the moment he becomes a co-author of the exposure.*

**THE MANAGER** *[to the **Step-Daughter**].* We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

*She knows the wall, the screen, the exact placement — the knowledge of someone who memorized every object in a room they wanted to escape.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[she knows the geography of that room — knows where Madame Pace kept everything].* Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

*Compensating for the wrong sofa with a surplus of smaller props — logistical overkill that cannot repair the larger failure of fidelity.*

**THE MANAGER.** See how many we've got and bring them all.

*Wordless efficiency: the theatre services the scene without pausing to ask what happened there.*

**PLAYER 2** *[a half-nod; she is already on her way].* Right.

*The **Property Man** hurries off to obey his orders. While he is putting the things in their places, the **Manager** talks to the **Prompter** and then with the **Characters** and the **Actors**.*

*Asking the Prompter for something 'out of the ordinary' quietly concedes that ordinary theatrical procedure has already been left behind.*

**THE MANAGER** *[to **Prompter**].* Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. *[Hands him some sheets of paper.]* And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

*The doubled question — 'shorthand? in shorthand?' — betrays surprise that a living performance will need a written record at all.*

**PLAYER 3** *[looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour].* Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand?*

*Pleasant surprise at a basic skill exposes how improvised the enterprise has become; he is solving problems he never anticipated because he never anticipated these Characters.*

**THE MANAGER** *[pleasantly surprised].* Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

*'A little' hedges against an extraordinary assignment — he already senses this shorthand will record something that should not be lost.*

**PLAYER 3.** Yes, a little.

*Paper and stage hands mobilizing: the theatre's administrative apparatus gearing up to witness something it cannot fully contain.*

**THE MANAGER.** Good! [Turning to a **Stage Hand**.] Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. [The **Stage Hand** goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the **Prompter**.]

*Directing the actors to become audience inverts the normal hierarchy — the Characters have displaced the professionals from the center of the stage.*

**THE MANAGER** [to **Prompter**]. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. [Then addressing the **Actors**.] Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here [Pointing to the left.] and listen attentively.

*An unfinished objection is all she manages; the Leading Lady senses her role is being evacuated before she knows what will replace it.*

**PLAYER 2.** But, excuse me, we...

*'You won't have to improvise' is ironic reassurance — the Characters are about to force exactly the unscripted reality that trained actors fear most.*

**THE MANAGER** [guessing her thought]. Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

*Vanity turning to acid: the applause joke is how the Leading Man wraps his demotion in theatrical gossip to save face.*

**PLAYER 1.** What do we do, then — sit and applaud?

*'They're going to act now' treats the Characters' existence as a demonstration piece — a pedagogical exercise for his company rather than a collision with reality.*

**THE MANAGER.** Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

*Bewilderment at the word 'rehearsal' cuts to the philosophical core: a fixed Character does not rehearse its reality, it simply lives it.*

**THE FATHER** [as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage]. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

*Clarifying that the rehearsal is for the Actors inadvertently concedes that the Characters need no preparation because they already are.*

**THE MANAGER.** A rehearsal for them. [Points to the **Actors**.]

*The unfinished sentence proves its own point: a Character does not argue for its existence — it simply is the argument, and the incomplete clause enacts that.*

**THE FATHER.** But since we are the characters...

*Pointing to the prompter's box to locate theatrical authority in text is precisely what these bookless Characters have come to destabilize.*

**THE MANAGER.** All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" [Pointing towards **Prompter's box**.] — when there is a "book"!

*The Actors' desire to 'be' the Characters is, for the Father, proof that Characters possess a reality the Actors can only approximate.*

**THE FATHER.** I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

*Sarcastic 'grand' covers real fear: if Characters perform themselves, the theatre's mediating function — and his own authority — become redundant.*

**THE MANAGER.** Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

*'As we are' is his entire manifesto in three words — unmediated, uninterpreted, unacted — and also the most dangerous thing you can put on a stage.*

**THE FATHER.** As we are...

*The irony backfires: 'magnificent spectacle' is exactly what the Characters offer and exactly what the theatre cannot reproduce — he has stated his own defeat.*

**THE MANAGER.** I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

*'Furniture with opinions' is wounded pride, but it accidentally names the Actors' structural role once the Characters arrive — decoration for a drama that has outgrown them.*

**PLAYER 1** *[dry now, the joke costing him something]*. What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

*Laughter covers genuine unease; 'they cast themselves' surrenders authorial control while pretending to exercise it.*

**THE MANAGER.** You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! *[The Actors laugh.]* There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. *[To the Second Lady Lead.]* You play the Mother. *[To the Father.]* We must find her a name.

*Giving the real name is an act of fidelity that the theatre will immediately refuse — the gap between the real and the representable opens here.*

**THE FATHER.** Amalia, sir.

*Protocol, not malice: the theatre's need to sanitize lived identity into manageable fiction, dressed as a professional courtesy.*

**THE MANAGER.** But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

*The moment representation enters, he hears his own words 'ring false' — a precise, devastating diagnosis of what theatre does to real experience.*

**THE FATHER.** Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... *[Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the Second Lady Lead.]* I see this woman here *[Means the Mother.]* as Amalia. But do as you like. *[Gets more and more confused.]* I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

*Brisk efficiency papers over the Father's vertigo; assigning names and roles, he reclaims directorial ground by reducing persons to functions.*

**THE MANAGER.** Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: *[To Juvenile Lead.]* You are the Son. *[To the Leading Lady.]* You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

*Her laugh is not at the woman but at the obscenity of the substitution — that body cannot contain what the Step-Daughter carries, and she knows it in an instant.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[a single hard laugh, head turning]*. What? What? I — that woman there?

*Impatience, but also defensiveness: he chose the Leading Lady and cannot afford to have the choice mocked aloud.*

**THE MANAGER** *[angry]*. What is there to laugh at?

*'Reasonable lighting' lands beside 'respect' not as vanity but as a technical demand — she knows she will look wrong in this scene and is negotiating survival.*

**PLAYER 2** *[indignant]*. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go.

*Not contempt but something closer to pity: she is not laughing at the woman, but at the impossibility of the task assigned to her.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

*Flattery dressed as honour: he uses the theatre's institutional prestige to shut down the Step-Daughter's instinctive refusal of her substitute.*

**THE MANAGER** *[to Step-Daughter]*. You should feel honored to be played by...

*Wounded vanity fires faster than thought — 'that woman' lands like a slap, and she retaliates before she can stop herself.*

**PLAYER 2** *[at once, contemptuously]*. "That woman there"...

*Grief dressed as aesthetic objection: her self is not transferable, and no amount of resemblance can close that distance.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** But I wasn't speaking of you, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

*Philosophy is his armour — he seizes the opening and pivots from personal wound to metaphysics the moment raw feeling threatens to break through.*

**THE FATHER.** True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

*The Manager's creed against the Characters — a soul is nothing until his actors lend it a body; the drama's worth, if any, will be theirs, not the family's.*

**THE MANAGER.** Temperament, soul — to hell with all that! Your soul, or whatever you like to call it, takes shape *here*: my actors give it body, voice, gesture. They have given voice to material far loftier than this little drama of yours — and if it holds the stage at all, the merit will be theirs.

*Vulnerability weaponised — 'terrible suffering' is real and also strategic, deployed to reclaim moral ground from the Manager's dismissal.*

**THE FATHER.** I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

*Two dismissals in one breath: surface can stand in for essence, and on this stage the man himself simply cannot exist — an ontological eviction handed down as a stage direction.*

**THE MANAGER** *[cutting him short and out of patience]*. Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up... On the stage, you as yourself cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

*He suddenly grasps why the Author abandoned them: to be staged is to be falsified, and that falsification is worse than non-existence.*

**THE FATHER.** I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

*Chin lifted, bearing arranged — an actor performing dignity offstage, always auditioning, never not performing.*

**PLAYER 1** *[on his dignity — chin lifted, the bearing arranged]*. By me, if you've no objection.

*The bow and 'honored' are a trap: elaborate courtesy sets up the devastating 'but' that will erase the compliment entirely.*

**THE FATHER** *[with a small bow toward Player 1]*. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

*Vanity cracks the instant irony is suspected; he cannot distinguish sincerity from condescension and the uncertainty undoes him.*

**PLAYER 1** *[the dignity cracking]*. Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

*He drops the abstraction for the wound: you will never see how he feels inside, only how another imagines him — even his plea about judgement is really about being unseen.*

**THE FATHER.** It will be difficult to act me as I am. What you will see is how he imagines me — if he imagines me at all — never how I feel myself to be, in here. Whoever judges us ought to remember that.

*He cannot answer the Father's argument, so he buries it under stage management, pivoting to logistics as a form of refusal.*

**THE MANAGER.** Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the Actors and Characters.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the Step-Daughter.]* Is it all right as it is now?

*Not scenic criticism but a statement of identity: the real site of her humiliation cannot be reproduced, only approximated into insult.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

*Condescension — 'you can't possibly suppose' — masks genuine limitation; theatre is always approximation, and he will not admit it.*

**THE MANAGER.** My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the Father.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

*Bare confirmation, all intellectual scaffolding stripped away — the room suddenly real and close in a single syllable.*

**THE FATHER.** Yes.

*Brisk furniture-moving reduces the site of the Step-Daughter's degradation to props on a checklist, obscene in its efficiency.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The Stage Hands obey the order. To Property Man.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates Father.]*

*A mundane question that makes the absurdity plain: an instrument of shame is being requisitioned like a paperclip.*

**PLAYER 2.** An ordinary envelope?

*The one moment Father and Manager speak as one — both needing the same ordinary envelope to contain an extraordinary transaction.*

**THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER.** Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

*Crisp obedience: the machinery of theatre moves without moral pause, however freighted the object it has been sent to fetch.*

**PLAYER 2.** At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

*One woman simply swapped for another — the double correction lays bare the substitution at the heart of all theatrical representation.*

**THE MANAGER.** Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. *[The **Leading Lady** comes forward.]* No, no, you must wait. I meant her *[Indicating the **Step-Daughter**.]* You just watch —

*Compulsion, not performance pride: she needs to re-enact her degradation because only she can carry its full, unmediated weight.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[adding at once]*. How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

*Professional reflex misreads existential desperation as a competitive slight — the Leading Lady hears rivalry where there is only grief.*

**PLAYER 2** *[offended]*. I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

*His first real crack: he has been managing chaos all scene, and now even the cast list has a gap he cannot fill.*

**THE MANAGER** *[with his hands to his head]*. Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! *[Looks around as if lost.]* And this Madame Pace, where is she?

*A quiet sentence that reopens the metaphysical problem just when the Manager believed he had closed it — Pace exists on different terms.*

**THE FATHER.** She isn't with us, sir.

*His theatre-logic hits the wall the whole play keeps hitting — you cannot rehearse what refuses to arrive; and the impossible is about to walk in anyway.*

**THE MANAGER.** Then what the devil's to be done? I cannot rehearse a character who has not arrived.

*He asserts that Pace, like all of them, has autonomous fictional existence — a claim that will be proved, disturbingly, within moments.*

**THE FATHER.** But she is alive too.

*A mundane question exposing how theatre thinks in locations; existence without a mark on the stage plan is simply invisible.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, but where is she?

*Both conjuring-trick and thesis: he believes the props of her trade can summon the character who needs them.*

**THE FATHER.** One minute. Let me speak! *[Turning to the **Actresses**.]* If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

*Bafflement — the company cannot follow why the Father wants their hats; the conjuring has begun and they do not yet feel it.*

**PLAYER 1** *[half surprised, half laughing]*. Our hats?

*A reasonable question that is completely beside the point; he has not yet grasped that the Father is performing a genuine summoning.*

**THE MANAGER.** What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? *[The **Actors** laugh.]*

*Mantles added to hats — the ritual extends, each item placed with almost priestly care, each one an invocation.*

**THE FATHER.** Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

*Still clinging to the ordinary as the scene tips toward the uncanny — a small, human resistance.*

**PLAYER 2.** Why our hats?

*The question under the whole act: they no longer know what kind of event they are inside. The frame is dissolving.*

**PLAYER 3.** Are we still rehearsing?

*Courtesy kept scrupulously in place: politeness holds the actors inside a ritual they do not understand and have not consented to.*

**THE FATHER.** To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

*The **Players** take off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and go to hang them on the racks.*

*Two words name the logic of the summons: she is a creature of display, and she will come to where her merchandise is visible.*

**THE FATHER.** Exactly; just like that, on show.

*Institutional reason confronting something it cannot categorise — he needs a rational explanation before he can take another step.*

**THE MANAGER.** May we know why?

*Pirandello's thesis made literal: fiction is not written but called into being by conditions, and the Father has just proved it.*

**THE FATHER.** I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? *[Inviting the **Actors** to look towards the exit at back of stage.]* Look! Look!

## PART II — THE APPARITION

*The door at the back of stage opens and **Madame Pace** enters and takes a few steps forward. She is a fat, oldish woman with puffy oxygenated hair, rouged and powdered, dressed with a comical elegance in black silk. Round her waist is a long silver chain from which hangs a pair of scissors. The audience should read her at first as absurd — an apparition out of a comic operetta, conjured from the costume department of every small shop in Lausanne that has ever overcharged a foreigner. She has come, however, from somewhere real: a back room off the rue de Bourg, where the accounts book lies open on a desk and a customer is waiting. The comedy is her front. The scissors at her waist are not. The **Step-Daughter** runs over to her at once amid the stupor of the actors.*

*Triumph, not welcome — Madame Pace's arrival vindicates every word the Step-Daughter has said and strips the room of any comfortable distance.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[turning towards her]*. There she is! There she is!

*Radiant because he needs the stage to confirm his version of events; Pace's entrance feels to him like proof, not accusation.*

**THE FATHER** *[radiant]*. It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

*What he cannot explain becomes, by reflex, a violation of the rules he is there to enforce — the indignation is purely self-protective.*

**THE MANAGER** *[conquering his surprise, and then becoming indignant]*. What sort of a trick is this?

*Hand pressed to chest, the Leading Man checks that he still exists — the real threat is not the missing script but his own sudden insubstantiality beside these intruders.*

**PLAYER 1** *[almost at the same time — a hand pressed flat to his chest, as if checking he is still there]*. What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

*The youngest player, badly unnerved: he reaches for the moment she entered and finds none to put her in — the uncanny lands hardest on him.*

**PLAYER 3.** Where did she come from? She wasn't here a moment ago. She wasn't anywhere.

*Bravado as a covering action — she names it a trick to steady herself, but the assertion curdles into a question she needs someone else to answer.*

**PLAYER 2.** It's some trick. Someone arranged this. *[the certainty leaves her]* ...Didn't they?

*He turns the actors' protest into the play's credo — the stage has just made something truer than any performance; the conjured Pace outranks the actress who would fake her.*

**THE FATHER** *[dominating the protests]*. Excuse me — all of you. Why so eager to destroy, in the name of your ordinary little truth, a thing the stage itself has just conjured into being? Which of your actresses was to play Madame Pace? Here she is — Madame Pace herself. Any actress you cast would be less true than the woman standing there. That is all.

*But the scene between the **Step-Daughter** and **Madame Pace** has already begun despite the protest of the actors and the reply of **The Father**. It has begun quietly, naturally, in a manner impossible for the stage. So when the actors, called to attention by **The Father**, turn round and see **Madame Pace**, who has placed one hand under the*

*Step-Daughter's chin to raise her head, they observe her at first with great attention, but hearing her speak in an unintelligible manner their interest begins to wane.*

*Two identical monosyllables, stalling — the Manager is buying time while his authority catches up with an event he has no procedure for.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well? well?

*The cupped ear, the projecting bearing — professional habit is the only instrument the company has left for processing the uncanny.*

**PLAYER 1** *[cupping a hand to his ear, the bearing of a man used to being heard at the back of the house].* What does she say? Madame — speak up.

*Demanding volume is also a demand for safety: if it is loud enough to be theatre, it is contained enough not to be real.*

**PLAYER 3.** Louder! Louder please!

*She draws a line between two kinds of speech — loud shaming accusation aimed at the Father, and the soft transactional quiet of Pace's world — knowing both from the inside.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[leaving Madame Pace, who smiles a Sphinx-like smile, and advancing towards the actors].* Louder? Louder? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. *[Indicates Father.]* But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

*Asking characters who actually lived that privacy to simulate it for an audience's comfort is an unwitting cruelty the Manager cannot hear in his own instruction.*

**THE MANAGER.** Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you. What will it be when the public's in the theatre? And anyway, you can very well speak up now among yourselves, since we shan't be present to listen to you as we are now. You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you.

*The Step-Daughter, level and unhurried, makes a sign of disagreement two or three times with her finger.*

*More alarmed than curious — a single 'no' from a character is insubordination to the whole theatrical contract he manages.*

**THE MANAGER.** What do you mean by no?

*The quiet warning reintroduces the Father as the hidden listener; the danger is not the audience but the man behind the door who already knows.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[low, no theatrics].* There's someone who will hear us if she *[Indicating Madame Pace.]* speaks out loud.

*The Manager's consternation and the actors' laughter are the same reflex — converting genuine dread into social noise.*

**THE MANAGER** *[in consternation].* What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now? *[The Actors burst out laughing.]*

*The offer to step behind the door is cooperative and self-serving at once: he can re-enter as the character rather than the accused man standing in full light.*

**THE FATHER.** No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready. *[Moves away.]*

*An appeal to theatrical convention not to protect the scene but to reassert authority over a sequence he did not choreograph.*

**THE MANAGER** *[stopping him].* No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

*Not artistic enthusiasm — she is hunting the moment of exposure and fears any delay will allow the Father or the Manager to soften what she needs left raw.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[interrupting him].* No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

*Insisting on the Pace scene first as a director's procedure, unaware he is asking her to rehearse the prelude to her own degradation on demand.*

**THE MANAGER** *[shouting].* But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... *[Indicates Madame Pace.]* Do you understand?...

*Clipped and matter-of-fact, she drains the scene of sentiment — the story has been rehearsed so many times it has become inventory.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that my mother's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

*The elaborate self-introduction is a performance of respectability that names its own corruption: the ledger-logic — 'the book, she balance' — is the horror dressed as bookkeeping.*

**MADAME PACE** *[coming forward with an air of great importance, hand pressed to her chest, very pleased indeed to be here].* Good morning, good morning, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. *[A small bow to the room; the silver chain at her waist swings once.]* Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. *[Smiling, the smile of a hostess at her own front door.]* I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. *[The smile, unchanged.]* Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

*Note. Madame Pace speaks in a heavy accent, not in another language — an Italian-Swiss woman who has lived in French Lausanne too long and not long enough. The foreignness lives in the music of the voice and the broken grammar; the page keeps the words plain and lets the actor carry the sound. Played for full comedy on her arrival; played for full chill by her exit. The audience must laugh at her first line. They must regret laughing by her last.*

*Genuinely alarmed beneath the comedy — Pace's accent reduces operatic villainy to something petty and mercantile, which turns out to be worse than a proper melodrama villain.*

**THE MANAGER** *[alarmed].* What? What? She talks like that? *[The Actors burst out laughing again.]*

*She laughs with the actors, but her laughter is knowing and a little cruel — the accent is funny precisely because it made her own degradation sound ridiculous.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[also laughing].* Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

*By placing her clients on the same rhythm as the bells of Saint-François, Pace reveals that her trade is built into the town's civic heartbeat.*

**MADAME PACE.** It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. *[A small shrug, the smile.]* Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

*Delighted by 'comic relief,' he misreads exploitation as theatrical texture — a professional error so spectacular it becomes its own indictment.*

**THE MANAGER.** Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

*She reclaims the laugh as a weapon, showing how Pace's ledger-language makes violation sound like commerce and how that very absurdity is what lets the paying men live with themselves.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

*Portrait of the 'polite' client delivered with the serenity of a satisfied hostess — she describes the erasure of the girl's name and face as though praising a reliable supplier.*

**MADAME PACE.** Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. *[The smile, unchanged.]* He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. *[The smile.]* And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

*Years of self-silencing finally outrun her body — the Wednesday tea, the knowledge half-held, the deliberate not-seeing all confessed in the same breath as the accusation.*

**THE MOTHER** *[jumping up amid the amazement and consternation of the actors who had not been noticing her. They move to restrain her — and the voice that comes out of her is the one she has not used for years, and once it starts it comes out faster than her body can carry it].* You old devil! You murderess! *[Trembling, but the voice does not stop.]* Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame, every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. *[Her hand, briefly, at her own chest.]* May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

*The rush to calm her mother carries a flicker of fear: the raw voice she hears is the wound beneath the weapon, and it threatens to undo the cold control she has built.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[running over to calm her Mother — and a little frightened, perhaps, by the voice she has just heard come out of her].* Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

*Returning to Pace's smile — mistaken for kindness — she names the deepest injury: she believed she had found a friend in her isolation, and that belief was the mechanism of her daughter's exploitation.*

**THE MOTHER** *[she cannot quite stop yet; the voice has been waiting too long].* And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

*Urging calm is as much about composure management as compassion; the scene is threatening to exceed the version of events he has prepared to argue.*

**THE FATHER** *[going to her also, at the same time, the body now beginning to give him away too].* Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

*After the torrent, the voice goes short again — collapse back into suppression, with just enough left to demand the source of the memory be removed.*

**THE MOTHER** *[the voice short again now, as if she has spent what she had].* Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

*Practical and protective at once; she is also quietly preventing her mother's pain from being absorbed into theatrical spectacle.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[to Manager].* It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

*The logical explanation conceals the real motive: the Mother's presence exposes a guilt that his careful philosophical framing cannot survive.*

**THE FATHER** *[to Manager].* They can't be here together. And here's why: that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

*Domesticating the eruption into a staging problem — 'first rough sketch' — so he can feel in charge of something again.*

**THE MANAGER.** It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... *[Turning to the Mother and leading her to her chair.]* Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

Meanwhile, the **Step-Daughter**, coming forward again, turns to **Madame Pace**.

A stage direction issued by a character: she is now directing the scene she is also living inside.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Come on, Madame, come on!

A grotesque pastoral — the hen-and-chicken rule makes the exploitation of girls sound like prudent animal husbandry.

**MADAME PACE** [offended, but not loud — the offense of a businesswoman whose house rules have been questioned]. Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. [Lifts a hand, as if to a small invisible bell.] The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

Ejecting Madame Pace is the one moment she exercises power — she stages herself as the agent, not the commodity.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. [Addressing the *Company* imperiously.] We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! [To **Madame Pace**.] You can go!

A contract renewal in disguise: by naming the debt, the hunger, the next silk, Pace ensures the Step-Daughter leaves still owing, still findable.

**MADAME PACE** [adjusting the silver chain at her waist; the scissors swing once]. Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. [Pauses at the door. The smile returned, calm now, almost tender.] And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. [Beat. The voice softer, the smile unchanged.] There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. [The scissors swing once more at her waist.] Don't you forget the name. [Exits. Not furious. Unhurried.]

Correcting his posture, cueing his line — she is directing him into the man he was so the stage can convict him.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [to the **Father**]. Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over here. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good morning, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

Two directors in one room; but his instruction to the Father is also an admission that he cannot resist seeing the scene played out.

**THE MANAGER**. Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? [To the **Father**, who looks undecided and perplexed.] Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

The **Father** does as he is told, looking troubled and perplexed at first. But as soon as he begins to move, the reality of the action affects him, and he begins to smile and to be more natural. The **Actors** watch intently.

The whispered 'ready?' to the Prompter shows the machinery of theatre swallowing a live wound: the scene is already being turned into a text to be recorded.

**THE MANAGER** [sotto voce, quickly to the **Prompter** in his box]. Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

Composure is the character's technique — the mask of normalcy worn by a man who has done this before and knows exactly how to wear it.

**THE FATHER** [coming forward, composed now — this is the scene, this is the man he was, that man did not show what he was feeling]. Good afternoon, Miss.

A lifetime of revulsion held behind a single decorous phrase — the bow is the posture of submission, the disgust is the truth beneath it.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [head bowed down slightly, with restrained disgust]. Good afternoon!

Not conscience — it is the calculation of risk, dressed briefly in the clothes of surprise, as he realises how young she is.

**THE FATHER** [looks under her hat which partly covers her face. Perceiving she is very young, he makes an exclamation, partly of surprise, partly of fear lest he compromise himself in a risky adventure]. Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

Two syllables that confirm she has been here before and has long since run out of energy to pretend otherwise.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[the rehearsed bow — no softness in it].* No sir.

Escalating from 'once' to 'more than once,' he reassures himself that prior visits have established a precedent that removes his responsibility.

**THE FATHER.** You've been here before, eh? *[Then seeing her nod agreement.]* More than once? *[Waits for her to answer, looks under her hat, smiles, and then says.]* Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

She forestalls him on the hat because she will not be touched before she chooses to be — removing it herself is the last act of self-possession available to her.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[anticipating him and with veiled disgust].* No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Takes it off quickly.]*

The **Mother**, who watches the progress of the scene with **The Son** beside her, the Child-bundle held tight in her arms and the Boy-chair pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.

Muffled behind her hands, the prayer is not theatrical; it is the sound of a parent for whom witnessing has become indistinguishable from complicity.

**THE MOTHER** *[without lifting her head from her hands].* Oh, my God. My God.

The gift of a smarter hat is the transaction dressed as gallantry — delivered with the fluency of a man who has rehearsed this scene before.

**THE FATHER** *[playing his part with a touch of gallantry].* Give it to me! I'll put it down. *[Takes hat from her hands.]* But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

A purely professional anxiety about the hats that, by its absurd timing, accidentally names the commodification happening on stage.

**PLAYER 1** *[interrupting — protective of the company's property, the senior actor surfacing through the wig].* I say... those are our hats, you know.

His fury at the interruption shows captivation: he wants the scene to continue more than he wants decorum restored, so he protects it.

**THE MANAGER** *[furious].* Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. *[To the Step-Daughter.]* Begin again, please!

Not a line — a character who has already decided where this ends, holding her position against the transaction's momentum.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[continuing].* No thank you, sir.

Invoking Pace as the silent partner whose approval lubricates the exchange, he shows the full triangulation of the arrangement.

**THE FATHER.** Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

The refusal carries its real reason just below the surface — the first hint of the black dress and what it means.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** No, no! I couldn't wear it!

The seducer's all-purpose solvent: every obstacle is reframed as a social inconvenience, never as a moral one.

**THE FATHER.** Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

Touching the black dress once, she lets mourning enter the transaction — a single restrained gesture that changes everything in the room.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[level, not pleading].* No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her black dress, once.]*

The pause before 'in mourning' is the play's most nakedly exposed moment of ethical failure: the audience watches a man choose a polished apology over an honest reckoning.

**THE FATHER** *[a beat — the smallest pause. He did not, in fact, say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said something else. The audience must see the lie being made in real time.].* ... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

*She swallows disgust and forces a smile — not forgiveness, but a bid to seize the scene back before the Father narrates it for her.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[forcing herself to conquer her indignation and nausea].* Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. *[Tries to smile.]* I must forget that I am dressed so...

*Scissors applied to the transcript: pain that can't be shaped into theatre gets cut, and the Manager calls the remainder "fine."*

**THE MANAGER** *[interrupting and turning to the **Prompter**].* Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. *[Then to the **Father** and **Step-Daughter**.]* Fine! it's going fine! *[To the **Father** only.]* And now you can go on as we arranged. *[To the **Actors**.]* Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

*Hunger, not impatience — she wants the seduction played to its ugliest end before anyone onstage can soften it.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

*Treating it lightly is the house rule: the Manager smooths trauma into entertainment so audiences can watch without being hurt.*

**THE MANAGER.** Have a little patience! *[To the **Actors**.]* Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

*Vanity rushes in to fill the vacuum — he claims ownership of a scene he hasn't entered and a pain he cannot touch.*

**PLAYER 1.** Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

### PART III — THE SUBSTITUTION

*Breezy professional confidence: she has done a thousand scenes harder than this and has no stake in its real wound.*

**PLAYER 2** *[the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this].* Of course. It's easy enough. *[To **Leading Man**.]* Shall you and I try it now?

*Eager readiness before anyone has finished speaking — theatrical vanity indifferent to what the original scene actually cost.*

**PLAYER 1.** Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. *[Exit to make his entrance.]*

*Logistics swallow the living moment whole; he is already redistributing bodies before the Characters have drawn breath.*

**THE MANAGER** *[to **Leading Lady**].* See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

*A diva's small act of reclamation — hat back on before surrendering to someone else's story.*

**PLAYER 2.** One minute. I want to put my hat on again. *[Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]*

*Grief becomes a stage direction: bowed head as costume note, anguish rewritten as blocking.*

**THE MANAGER.** Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

*Flat, factual, possessive: she will not let a wrong body carry her grief without protest.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** But she isn't dressed in black.

*"More effectively" turns trauma into a professional competition — the **Leading Lady** reaches for victory where the **Step-Daughter** lived through humiliation.*

**PLAYER 2** *[an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed].* But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

*Clapping hands enforce momentum over truth; "learn something" is an insult dressed as pedagogy.*

**THE MANAGER** *[to **Step-Daughter**].* Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. *[Clapping his hands.]* Come on! come on! Entrance, please! *[The door at rear of stage opens, and the **Leading Man** enters with the lively manner of an old gallant. The rendering of the scene by the **Actors** from the very first words is seen to be quite a different thing, though it has not in any way the air of a parody. Naturally, the **Step-Daughter** and the **Father**, not being able to recognize themselves in the **Leading Lady** and the **Leading Man**, who deliver their words in different tones and with a different psychology, express, sometimes with smiles, sometimes with gestures, the impression they receive.]*

*A generic greeting with no guilt behind it — without the **Father**'s haunted gaze, the scene is already a different event.*

**PLAYER 1.** Good afternoon, Miss...

Two words, and his control collapses: watching his own memory mis-embodied is physically unbearable.

**THE FATHER** [at once unable to contain himself]. No! no!

The **Step-Daughter** noticing the way the **Leading Man** enters, bursts out laughing.

Both laughter and protest feel like sabotage; the Manager's fury cannot distinguish between emotional responses and disciplinary problems.

**THE MANAGER** [furious]. Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

She weaponises her own body as evidence — her laughter proves the imitation false, contempt becoming theatrical testimony.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady [Indicating **Leading Lady**.] stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

Not concession but reclamation: he reaches for the precise details that constitute his version of events.

**THE FATHER**. Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

"Rubbish" settles it — the Manager's priority is theatrical shape, not the accuracy of a lived event.

**THE MANAGER**. Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

Comic self-importance about blocking, but it exposes how utterly disconnected he is from the scene's moral weight.

**PLAYER 1** [the practised gallantry already in his shoulders before he speaks]. If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

"It goes fine" — the moment his authority becomes self-deception; he cannot see what the Characters standing beside him see.

**THE MANAGER**. Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. [Waiting for the **Actors** to begin again.] Well?

Bare repetition, stripped of any felt content: the hollowness of the imitation is now audible.

**PLAYER 1**. Good afternoon, Miss.

Three words, perfectly calibrated to be polite and empty — none of the Step-Daughter's compelled, shamed compliance.

**PLAYER 2**. Good afternoon.

Recognition and fear delivered as technical beats; beside the Father's original guilt, it reads as theatrical shorthand.

**PLAYER 1** [imitating the gesture of the **Father** when he looked under the hat, and then expressing quite clearly first satisfaction and then fear]. Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

Unable to resist stepping into the scene himself, he exposes his controlling need to shape reality from the inside.

**THE MANAGER**. Good — but not so heavily. [Acts it himself.] And you say: "No, sir."

Technically correct, emotionally inert: a single obedient line that lays bare the gap between compliance and lived submission.

**PLAYER 2**. No, sir.

A gallant's knowing gambit; the Father's version held darker knowledge — something that implicated him, not her.

**PLAYER 1**. You've been here before, more than once.

Choreographed disgust reduced to a traffic signal: the Step-Daughter's involuntary shame becomes a rehearsable head movement.

**THE MANAGER**. No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?" [The **Leading Lady** lifts up her head slightly and closes her eyes as though in disgust. Then she inclines her head twice.]

Not amusement — horror breaking through as uncontrollable, anguished release at the parody of her worst moment.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [unable to contain herself]. Oh my God! [Puts a hand to her mouth to prevent herself from laughing.]

*His oblivious question shows he cannot perceive the emotional reality happening in plain sight beside his rehearsal.*

**THE MANAGER** [turning round]. What's the matter?

*She retreats, calculating that explanation is useless — the Manager will never understand what he has just witnessed.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Nothing, nothing!

*Two words of impatience: the scene's machinery must never stop for feeling.*

**THE MANAGER** [to *Leading Man*]. Go on!

*Practiced seducer's lightness; the Father's version carried the weight of a man who knows exactly where this leads.*

**PLAYER 1.** You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

*The **Leading Man** says this last speech in such a tone and with such gestures that the **Step-Daughter**, hand pressed to her mouth, struggles to keep from laughing aloud.*

*An urgent whisper betrays his own anxiety — he knows the scene is fragile and is holding it together by willpower alone.*

**THE MANAGER** [low, firm, to the players]. Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

*Smooth professional autonomy; the Step-Daughter's original act would have been trembling, deliberate, utterly different.*

**PLAYER 2** [recovering, back into the rehearsed register]. No sir... I'll do it myself. [Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]

*Flattery as a well-oiled key — what the Father felt reaching for the hat was something far more ambivalent.*

**PLAYER 1** [a step closer, practised gallantry]. Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

*A scripted beat, not the Step-Daughter's mixture of need and self-disgust.*

**PLAYER 2** [politely demure]. No thank you, sir.

*Light insistence reads as charming theatre; the Father's original pressure came from a more compromised place entirely.*

**PLAYER 1** [the smile he has used a thousand times]. Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

*An actress hitting her mark: the mourning revelation lands as a practised gesture rather than a girl exposing a wound.*

**PLAYER 2** [eyes downcast, on cue]. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. [Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]

*Courtesy performed to order; the Father's original apology came out of genuine, complicated shame.*

**PLAYER 1** [a beat, then deeply gallant]. ...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

*A short, theatrical pause. The **Father** turns his face away. The **Step-Daughter** is no longer struggling not to laugh — she is staring.*

*Executed exactly where directed — the precision of the coached catch makes the falseness visible.*

**PLAYER 2** [the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

*Satisfied note-taking treats the Characters' living memory as raw material to be efficiently processed and filed.*

**THE MANAGER** [satisfied, to the *Prompter*]. Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

*A tiny, devastating correction: this is the line where theatrical approximation becomes a lie about what actually happened.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [low, almost to herself]. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

*To him the words are interchangeable; to her every syllable is scarred into memory — the Manager cannot hear the difference.*

**THE MANAGER.** We've done that bit. Move on.

*"His hand stayed on the hat" restores the physical detail the theatre erased; the body's stillness was the scene's real meaning.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

*Quiet corroboration, not defence: for one brief, painful moment Father and Step-Daughter share the same memory.*

**THE FATHER** *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said "Oh."

*A professional ultimatum that makes explicit the incompatibility: their presence doesn't enrich the scene — it dissolves the fiction.*

**PLAYER 2** *[breaking character, to **Manager**]*. Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

*Authority draining away in three words; he is managing a situation he no longer controls, just keeping the scene alive.*

**THE MANAGER** *[tired]*. They will sit down.

*Sitting down would surrender the only ground she still holds in this theatre — refusal is self-preservation.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[hard, decisive]*. We will not.

*Her wounded-diva exit threat is also an unintended truth: her dignity is professional, not personal — she can afford to leave.*

**PLAYER 2** *[the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

*A visible calculation crosses his face before he speaks; his exit is a decision, not an emotion.*

**PLAYER 1** *[two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

*"For once and all" betrays exhaustion — he is no longer directing a play, he is refereeing a collision he cannot stop.*

**THE MANAGER** *[shouting to **Step-Daughter**]*. Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

*Surprising precisely because it is uncharacteristic: beneath the contempt lives a creature who still wants to be seen.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Forgive me! forgive me!

*He cannot name what is really happening, so he calls it bad manners — scolding entirely about social form.*

**THE MANAGER.** You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

*Protection or control, genuine care or image management — the Father's instinct to intercede is ambiguous at its root.*

**THE FATHER** *[endeavouring to intervene]*. Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

*"Absolutely disgusting" reaches for propriety's language because he has no words for what the Characters actually carry.*

**THE MANAGER.** Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

*He reaches for "strange" because he cannot say true; the wrongness is ontological — those actors are simply not them.*

**THE FATHER.** Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

*Three repetitions — "Strange? Why strange? Where?" — reveal defensive incomprehension; he feels accused but cannot locate the charge.*

**THE MANAGER.** Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

*The play's central wound stated plainly: imitation and identity cannot coincide.*

**THE FATHER.** No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

*"I should hope not" is a logical defence and an unwitting confession that theatre is structurally unable to deliver what they need.*

**THE MANAGER.** I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

*The wound, not the theory — he watches them do it well and feels the dispossession: what the actors make is real, and it is no longer his.*

**THE FATHER.** Just so — actors. They act our parts exceedingly well. But what comes out is theirs now, and no longer ours — and we must stand here and watch it happen.

*Brushing off the Father's protest by citing his own earlier ruling, he retreats into professional habit to mask a growing unease.*

**THE MANAGER.** But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

*Capitulation dressed as comprehension — he retreats into repeated compliance, buying time to find another angle of attack.*

**THE FATHER.** Yes, I understand... I understand...

*He expels the author-figure to restore order, then turns to the characters with an irritation that has nowhere clean to land.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well then, let's have no more of it! *[Turning to the Actors.]* We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! *[Turning to Father and Step-Daughter.]* Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

*Her ominous stillness is predatory; she has stopped resisting and started counting down to the moment that will expose the Father.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

*Reducing a degrading negotiation to cue-and-question, he tidies the scene into shorthand that sanitises everything it touches.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you *[Addressing the Father.]* come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her...

*A trap being sprung — she wants him to name exactly what was asked so it enters the record on her terms.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[interrupting]*. What?

*He answers innocently, unaware the mourning question is the fuse he is about to light.*

**THE MANAGER.** Why she is in mourning.

*She replaces the Manager's genteel blocking with the actual words from Madame Pace's room, weaponising verbatim memory against polite fiction.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

*His excitement is purely commercial; 'riot in the theatre' means a hit, and he values sensation over the human reality he is staging.*

**THE MANAGER.** Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

*Three words strip the debate to its core: she is the custodian of what really happened and will not let fiction overwrite it.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** But it's the truth!

*He openly admits truth has a box-office ceiling — a candid confession that the stage is a negotiation between fact and palatability.*

**THE MANAGER.** What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

*Not genuine enquiry but an invitation for him to show his hand so she can refuse it and hold her ground as truth's guardian.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** What do you want to do then?

*Classic directorial power-move: promise resolution, withhold the details, keep the characters compliant on the strength of your authority alone.*

**THE MANAGER.** You'll see, you'll see! Leave it to me.

*She delivers a savage précis of the sentimental version he would stage, mocking its falsity and insisting on the childhood detail as the true horror.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, the way one speaks to a child — *well, let's take this little dress off.*

*His hands-through-hair betrays real disturbance; for once the theatre professional is not managing the content but genuinely rattled by it.*

**THE MANAGER** *[running his hands through his hair]*. For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

*Dropping the pretence of performance, she lets stark repetition do the work — the bare fact must stand regardless of theatrical convention.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[no longer playing]*. The truth. The truth.

*He concedes her horror privately while denying it publicly; 'it won't go' is commercial self-interest dressed as aesthetic judgement.*

**THE MANAGER**. It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

*Her threat to leave is not a gambit but a genuine assertion of self-respect — she would rather have no stage than a falsified one.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Not possible, eh? Very well! I'm much obliged to you — but I'm off!

*He needs her now, and the plea for calm makes that visible; the power dynamic has silently shifted and he is playing catch-up.*

**THE MANAGER**. Now be reasonable! Don't lose your temper!

*She names the back-room deal with precision, articulating the gap between his guilt-as-philosophy and her experience-as-wound.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part*.

*His lecture on dramatic economy exposes theatre's formal violence against lives that exceed its containers; the softening at the end is entirely strategic.*

**THE MANAGER** *[annoyed, shaking his shoulders]*. Ah! Just your part! But there are other parts than yours — his *[Indicating the Father.]* and hers *[Indicating the Mother.]*. On the stage you can't have one character overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them into a neat little framework and act what isactable. From your point of view, every character would tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. *[softening, sitting on the edge of the table]* You must restrain yourself, my dear — in your own interest, too — because this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

*Head lowered, she concedes his point in form while refusing it in substance — the other characters exist for her only as extensions of the Father's guilt.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[head lowered, not yielding]*. It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

*Genuine puzzlement: he has been thinking in roles, not in relational chains, and her logic of inherited ruin is outside his dramaturgical vocabulary.*

**THE MANAGER** *[not understanding]*. What? The others? What do you mean?

*She articulates a moral genealogy in which the first violation contaminates everything downstream — a philosophical indictment, not self-pity.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

*He tries to convert moral accountability into dramatic action, reducing her accusation to a cue in someone else's scene.*

**THE MANAGER**. Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

*Her rhetorical question dismantles the plan to spare the Father: the child coming out of school is the detail that makes guilt irrefutable, and she is moved by her own memory.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school? *[She is moved.] [The Mother at this point is overcome with emotion, and breaks out into a fit of crying. All are touched. A long pause.]*

*After the Mother's breakdown she pivots to cold strategy, offering the Manager exactly what he wants while setting terms that will strip away his comfortable version.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[as soon as the **Mother** becomes a little quieter, adds resolutely and gravely]*. At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

*His eager agreement exposes his instrumentalism — 'as much of it as is possible' — he will harvest the truth only to the depth the production can use.*

**THE MANAGER**. Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

*Asking the Mother to leave is her cruelest editorial act: she intends to replay the scene that broke their family without any witness who could stop it.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

*From passive suffering into active refusal — the only moment she intervenes directly, making audible the pain she normally absorbs in silence.*

**THE MOTHER** *[changing her low plaint into a sharp cry]*. No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

*His 'only to try it' trivialises a reenactment the Mother experiences as happening now; theatrical bracketing of 'rehearsal' is meaningless to her.*

**THE MANAGER**. But it's only to try it.

*Speaking to the children rather than the room, she makes clear her suffering is not performed for the Manager's benefit — she lives in a perpetual present.*

**THE MOTHER** *[to the Child-bundle, not to the room]*. I can't bear it. I can't.

*He cannot grasp that for the Mother the past is not past; 'it has happened already' is theatrically logical and humanly irrelevant.*

**THE MANAGER**. But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

*Refusing the past tense entirely, she insists the torture is present-continuous, the children are anchors to it, and the Step-Daughter's flight is a second abandonment.*

**THE MOTHER** *[the Child-bundle in one arm, the other hand on the Boy-chair — both children held at once; she does not move from her chair for the whole speech]*. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

*He names the asymmetry: pinned to one shameful moment while she is freed by it, he appeals to the Manager for something like proportional justice.*

**THE FATHER**. The eternal moment. She *[Indicating the **Step-Daughter.**]* is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

*Converting the Mother's anguish into a dramaturgical pivot — 'nucleus of the whole first act' — he compulsively reduces pain to structure.*

**THE MANAGER**. I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise. *[Indicates the **Mother.**]*

*He reframes punishment as tragic inevitability, using 'passion' to cast himself as a suffering figure rather than an agent of harm.*

**THE FATHER**. Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

*Her physical staging of her own memory — head on breast, eyes closed, vein visible — is simultaneously a wound and a performance; she commands her mother's cry as a director would.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this *[She leans her head on the Father's breast.]*, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. *[Turning to the Mother.]* Cry out, mother. Cry out as you did then!

*The play's most purely maternal moment: she separates them bodily, names the relationship, and finally hurls accusation, her long silence broken into rage.*

**THE MOTHER** *[coming forward to separate them].* No! My daughter, my daughter! *[And after having pulled her away from him.]* You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

*His satisfied retreat toward the footlights — the audience's direction — marks the instant he stops being a collaborator and becomes a spectator.*

**THE MANAGER** *[walking backwards towards the footlights — the way a satisfied audience member would, if a satisfied audience member could walk].* Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

*His excitement confirms his deepest need: theatrical certification of what really happened is the closest he can get to absolution.*

**THE FATHER** *[going towards him excitedly].* Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

*His pleasure is aesthetic, not moral; he and the Father share satisfaction in the curtain-line for entirely different reasons.*

**THE MANAGER** *[convinced and pleased].* Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

*At the reiterated cry of **The Manager**, **The Machinist** lets the curtain down, leaving **The Manager** and **The Father** in front of it before the footlights.*

*His irritated explanation — curtain as signal, not command — reveals that the theatre's codes are not shared, a gap that will prove fatal later.*

**THE MANAGER.** The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. *[To the **Father**, while he pulls the curtain back to go on to the stage again.]* Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

# Act Three — The Question

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## PART I — THE TRAP

When the curtain goes up again, the two-level set of Act Two has been struck. The stage is empty except for a single short fountain basin set centre, its walls high enough that nobody can see inside. The **Mother** is sitting on the right, the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair leaned against her knee. The **Son** is on the same side, but away from the others. He seems bored, angry, and full of shame. The **Father** and the **Step-Daughter** are also seated towards the right front. On the other side (left) are the **Actors**, much in the positions they occupied before the curtain was lowered. Only the **Manager** is standing up in the middle of the stage, with his hand closed over his mouth in the act of meditating.

Shrugging off the philosophical fog, he claims command he doesn't fully have — the breezy confidence is there to convince himself as much as the Characters.

**THE MANAGER** [shaking his shoulders after a brief pause]. Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

She maps entry, resistance, and agency in one breath — against the Father's will, against the Son's, she came in anyway.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Our entry into his house [Indicates **Father**.] in spite of him... [Indicates the **Son**.]

Impatience as armour: he needs the Characters to stop owning the room and hand their pain back to a professional who can package it.

**THE MANAGER** [out of patience]. Leave it to me, I tell you!

She demands the record preserve her dissent, so no future accusation can claim she colluded in her own humiliation.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

An involuntary shake, not speech — grief too old for argument, released as punctuation from a body that cannot stay silent.

**THE MOTHER** [from her corner; the head shakes by itself, slowly, twice]. For all the good that's come of it...

Weaponising the Mother's suffering, she converts family ruin into a guilt-ledger she can keep billing the Father indefinitely.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [turning towards her quickly]. It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

Triple repetition betrays the opposite of comprehension — he is placating, not absorbing, desperate to move the scene forward.

**THE MANAGER** [impatiently]. I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

Raising the Child as both shield and witness, she aims her plea at posterity as much as the Manager — history must know she tried.

**THE MOTHER** [the Child-bundle held high against her chest so that her own face is half-hidden by it]. I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

She hijacks the Mother's testimony, redirects it as indictment, and savours the Son's cold distance as proof of the Father's lasting damage.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [interrupting indignantly and continuing for the **Mother**]... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. [To **Manager**.] Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

Theatrical time against private tribunal — the second act is already losing to the wound the Characters cannot stop reopening.

**THE MANAGER**. Are we going to begin this second act or not?

She claims dramaturgical authority: the story's geography is hers to dictate, not the Manager's to flatten into a convenient single set.

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER**. I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place in the garden, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

*A bare procedural prompt — he wants a practical answer but is about to receive an ontological one.*

**THE MANAGER.** Why not?

*She grounds the argument in the Son's isolation: shame lives indoors, not in any photogenic garden the Manager might prefer.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Because he *[Indicates the Son again.]* is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

*Retreating to production logistics, he uses the mechanics of stagecraft to avoid the emotional logic the Characters keep asserting.*

**THE MANAGER.** Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

*Nostalgia for fluid stagecraft doubles as a quiet dig at the Manager's rigidity — professional vanity dressed as historical fact.*

**PLAYER 1.** They used to change scenes like that once. When theatres had more hands than rules.

*Condescension toward old audiences slides into condescension toward the child on stage — he cannot see the horror he is casually dismissing.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

*Defending theatrical convention as audience service, she is unaware she is about to hand the Father his sharpest weapon.*

**PLAYER 2.** It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to *guess*.

*The word 'illusion' strikes like a slap — it is the precise term that would reduce his family's lived agony to mere craft.*

**THE FATHER** *[the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]*. The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

*Genuine bewilderment: he lives in a world where 'illusion' is neutral professional vocabulary, not a wound requiring an apology.*

**THE MANAGER** *[astounded]*. And why, if you please?

*Triple insistence on cruelty is itself a controlled display of injury — he is already philosophising the pain into a shape he can wield.*

**THE FATHER.** It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

*Trying to reclaim the word for professional use, he unwittingly demonstrates exactly why the Father cannot bear to hear it.*

**THE MANAGER.** But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

*Pride, not insight — the Leading Man wants his craft credited and stumbles straight into the Father's trap.*

**PLAYER 1.** With our acting.

*His tidy formula 'illusion of a reality' is meant to close the argument; instead it cracks the floor open.*

**THE MANAGER.** The illusion of a reality.

*Soft recovery is the composure-tell — gentleness is the windup before a philosophical ambush neither the Manager nor the Actors can avoid.*

**THE FATHER** *[recovering, voice softer]*. I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

*Professional indignation as self-protection: she cannot hear the accidental compliment buried inside the word 'game.'*

**PLAYER 2** *[interrupting indignantly]*. A *game*? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

*He rehabilitates 'game' as art, then pivots to the trap: their art creates the illusion of reality, but the Characters have no reality outside illusion.*

**THE FATHER.** I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

*His approving 'Precisely' is the last moment he holds the upper hand before the ground disappears.*

**THE MANAGER.** Precisely —!

*An unfinished sentence used as a rhetorical grenade — he dangles the implication and dares the Manager to follow it to its end.*

**THE FATHER.** Now, if you consider the fact that we *[Indicates himself and the other five **Characters**.]*, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

*Turning to his Actors for support, he converts collective bewilderment into a wall — defence by consensus against an argument none of them can answer.*

**THE MANAGER** *[astonished, looking at his **Actors**, who are also amazed]*. And what does that mean?

*Turning out toward the house and asking 'Who are you?' collapses the fourth wall; the trap is laid for the entire auditorium, not just the Manager.*

**THE FATHER** *[after watching them for a moment with a wan smile]*. As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. *[Brief pause. He goes a step or two nearer the **Manager** and adds.]* But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. *[Looks the **Manager** in the eyes. Then, slowly, turns out toward the house. A pause long enough to feel.]* Can you tell me who you are?

*His confident tautology 'I am myself' is the exact ground the Father is about to dissolve beneath him.*

**THE MANAGER** *[perplexed, half smiling]*. What? Who am I? I am myself.

*He halts mid-sentence — the pause is the argument; the Manager must feel the instability before it is given a name.*

**THE FATHER.** And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

*Laughter as first line of defence: the Actors mock what they cannot refute, and the Manager encourages it to re-establish hierarchy.*

**THE MANAGER.** I should say you were mad —! *[The **Actors** laugh.]*

*Naming the trap openly, he watches the Actors' too-loud laughter confirm his point — performance and reality have already blurred past recovery.*

**THE FATHER.** You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there *[Indicates the **Leading Man**.]* to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. *[Quiet.]* You see — I've caught you in a *trap*. *[The **Actors** laugh — too loudly, too quickly.]*

*Invoking procedural memory to escape a philosophical recursion he cannot win — 'we've had this before' as a procedural exit.*

**THE MANAGER** *[annoyed]*. But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

*Dropping the philosophy, he presses directly: 'Who are you?' is no longer rhetorical — he genuinely needs the Manager to confront his own contingency.*

**THE FATHER.** No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art *[Looking at the **Leading Lady** as if anticipating her.]* which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. *[Beat.]* Who are you?

*Performing outrage for his company, he deflects inward crisis outward — social dominance substituted for argument.*

**THE MANAGER** *[astonished and irritated, turning to his **Actors**]*. If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

*With quiet authority he distinguishes fixed character from fluid person — his most cogent moment, and his most self-serving: it justifies his own unchangeability.*

**THE FATHER** *[with dignity, but not offended]*. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

*Rank invoked as ontology — institutional title used as identity, the last card of a man losing a philosophical duel.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

*He makes the trap personal and physical — not theory but vertigo: the self you trust today already buried an earlier self, so why trust this one to last?*

**THE FATHER.** Only this: the man you are today once believed himself someone else entirely — someone who now means nothing to you, who barely seems to have existed. Don't you feel the ground go soft under you, knowing this *you* of today will look like an illusion to you tomorrow?

*Spoken for the whole room: the frame has dissolved, and no one left on stage is certain where the play ends and something else begins.*

**PLAYER 2** *[whispering]*. Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

*One factual sentence cuts through the Father's abstraction — his 'reality' was always territorial and predatory, and she was the territory.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[level, never raising her voice — colder than the philosophy]*. His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

*A silence. The **Father** does not answer. He has, for once, no answer. The face changes before the body does. When he speaks again, the argument is no longer clean.*

*Admitting he has been carried somewhere he didn't choose to go, he lets 'where does all this take us?' stand as both question and concession.*

**THE MANAGER** *[rattled now, and covering it]*. Well. Well. And where does all this take us anyway?

*Pressed for a destination, he says it plainly — they are only the 'illusion' he is accused of, and the Manager's solid self is no firmer; he merely believes it is.*

**THE FATHER.** Nowhere — only to this: we *[Indicating the **Characters**.]* have nothing but the illusion you call our reality. And you, sir, have no more than that. You only think you do.

*Irony attempted as exit — he suggests the Characters claim superiority — but it misfires because the Father will simply agree.*

**THE MANAGER** *[mocking him because the idea has unsettled him]*. Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

*Two words of absolute, unironic conviction — certainty that admits no qualification is more unsettling than any argument could be.*

**THE FATHER** *[the greatest seriousness — no smile]*. But of course. Without doubt.

*Surgical interruption: she translates the Father's metaphysics back into money and flesh, planting the afternoon at Madame Pace's in the middle of the room.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[the same temperature; addressing the room, not him]*. He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

*Hollow surprise — he hears an odd interjection, not the accusation of violation that has just been dropped into the conversation.*

**THE MANAGER.** Ah, really?

*Mild reproach assuming the Manager followed all along — he mistakes theatrical engagement for genuine comprehension.*

**THE FATHER.** Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

*Reducing the argument to a competition — who is more real — which is precisely the Father's point about the contingency of persons.*

**THE MANAGER.** More real than I?

*He leaves the conditional hanging — the Manager's reality-changes are already conceded; completing the sentence would only soften the blow.*

**THE FATHER.** If your reality can change from one day to another...

*Defensive relativism meant to normalise flux, but inadvertently confessing to having no stable self — the Father's position all along.*

**THE MANAGER.** But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

*Pre-empting the Father to drive the sharpest blade: their fixity is not a boast but proof of what was done and cannot be undone.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[before the Father can answer — flat, precise]*. His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

*Forced to the wall by her, the philosophy turns to horror — their reality is fixed, nailed shut, condemned to replay the wound every night the play is staged.*

**THE FATHER** *[the cry breaks; afterward the body goes still — not the composure he had at the start of this part, but a different stillness, as if he has just walked into the wall of his own argument she has shown him].* No, sir. Not ours. That is the difference. Our reality cannot change — it is fixed, forever; it cannot be other than what it is. *[Quieter, the horror finding him.]* And that is what should make you shudder as you come near us: yours shifts with the day, and ours is nailed shut. We are the thing we did. And we will do it again tonight. And tomorrow. And every night you choose to put us on.

## PART II — THE REFUSAL

*Patience exhausted, he flattens the Father's anguish into a scheduling problem — get on with it, or get out.*

**THE MANAGER.** Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy which you yourself have brought me here? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... *[Stops and looks him over from head to foot.]* Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

*Flat sincerity where the Manager expects a joke; the Father will not soften the claim by one syllable.*

**THE FATHER.** It is the simple truth, sir.

*He distrusts both the idea and the playwright it recalls, using professional contempt to mask real unease about what is invading his stage.*

**THE MANAGER.** Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it, because it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. If you want to know, it seems to me you are trying to imitate the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — although I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. In fact, I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. *[Turning to the Actors.]* And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

*Not abstraction now but defence — a suffering man claims the right to ask why; deny him that, he says, and you make him less than an animal.*

**THE FATHER.** I don't know your detested author, sir. I only know this: a man never thinks so hard as when he suffers — he must learn who did it to him, and whether he deserved it. Let me suffer in silence, like an animal, and you call it human. Let me ask *why*, and suddenly it is forbidden.

*Done imagining, he votes with his feet; the intellectual impasse has crossed from boredom into something that feels like danger.*

**PLAYER 1** *[low, to Player 3].* I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

*He tries to drag the room back to the practical — time, actors, tonight — before the Father's territory expands any further.*

**THE MANAGER** *[sharp now, no longer amused].* Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

*Two words the Manager uses interchangeably; the Father splits them apart and plants his last shred of dignity in the gap.*

**THE FATHER.** I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

*Any extended self-justification sounds like philosophy to a man who wants action — the Manager closes the distinction without hearing it.*

**THE MANAGER.** Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

*His defence escalates and finds the act's nerve — he reasons because he suffers, and names what the fountain will prove: a stage can rehearse pain but never feel it.*

**THE FATHER.** Because I am in pain, sir — and a man in pain reasons; he cannot help it. Pain is the one thing your stage can rehearse and never feel.

*Professional convention becomes a weapon — the Father's self-awareness is recast as a violation of theatrical decorum.*

**THE MANAGER** *[slaps the table].* I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who climbs right out of his part and makes speeches the way you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

*He defends the whole conceit: a living character outgrows his author — which is exactly why these six can stand here demanding the life he withheld.*

**THE FATHER.** Because authors hide the labour, sir. When a character is truly alive, the author only follows him — and the character takes on a life so far his own that he can be imagined in scenes the author never dreamed of.

*One knife-stroke of contempt — he theorises authorship even while denying he is the author, and she catches him at it.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[quiet]*. Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

*Quick agreement is a way of closing a door; he wants to move on, not face what the concession actually costs him.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, yes, I know this.

*He marshals the family as collective evidence, but his gesture toward the Mother and Step-Daughter shows he still appoints himself their spokesman.*

**THE FATHER.** So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — answer me if these characters left alive, and yet without life, weren't right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him to give them their stage life. We've all tried him in turn — I, she *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* and she. *[Indicating the Mother.]*

*Voicing the room's paralysis, he waits for someone senior to intervene — no one does, which is its own answer.*

**PLAYER 3** *[to no one in particular — the youngest voice in the room]*. Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should. *[No one does.]*

*Her one unguarded moment — the cold strategist remembers tempting the author in the dark, and the wound shows: she offered everything, and he turned away.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** I tempted him too — many times. He would sit at his writing-table at twilight, too tired to turn on the lamp, and the shadows would fill with us, come to tempt him. *[As if she saw herself still there.]* Leave us alone, I would whisper — the mother with her son, I with the little ones, and then I alone in the dark, offering him scene after scene. *[A sudden movement, as if she would seize the vision.]* Ah! my life! my life! And he turned away from all of it.

*Guilt shuffled as analysis: the Step-Daughter's excess drove the author away, not anything the Father himself did.*

**THE FATHER.** Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

*She refuses blame and offers a counter-reading — the author left out of artistic disgust, not because of her, and she knows her own worth.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? *[Goes close to the Manager to tell him, as if in confidence.]* In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

*His sudden directness is not solidarity; he agrees only to end the debate, briefly aligning with whoever might silence the Father.*

**THE SON** *[looking up, for once — directly at the Manager]*. Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

*Volunteering to moderate both the Step-Daughter and the Son, he bids for control while wearing the mask of reasonableness.*

**THE FATHER.** Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

*A single word, a wall — he will not be negotiated with, framed, or absorbed into anyone's managerial compromise.*

**THE SON.** No, nothing!

*The Father's own complaint turned back on him: a dry professional verdict that he is as excessive as those he criticises.*

**THE MANAGER.** You too get over the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

*He cannot see himself as others see him — the blind spot the whole play has been exposing from the start.*

**THE FATHER** *[genuinely surprised, almost wounded]*. I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

*The Manager itemises the excess precisely — the character-claim, the philosophy, the sheer volume — holding up a mirror the Father refuses to look into.*

**THE MANAGER.** Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

*He draws the line the Step-Daughter cannot: he will not be flattened into a single fact — the torment is his meaning, and to cut it is to erase him.*

**THE FATHER.** Take away my torment, sir — the torment that never gives me peace — and you suppress me. That's all. A man does not merely live; he gives his own life a meaning. I will not be reduced to a mere fact, as she [*Indicating the Step-Daughter.*] wants. It would destroy my reason for being.

*Comic but edged with real panic: neither character will yield, and the rehearsal is coming apart in front of everyone.*

**THE MANAGER.** Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

*Apparent surrender carrying a condition — sacrifice must stay within bearable limits — which makes it no surrender at all.*

**THE FATHER.** Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

*His aesthetic credo delivered as a verdict: drama is action, not interiority — a principle the Father's very existence refutes.*

**THE MANAGER.** You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

*He accepts the rule and instantly qualifies it out of existence; he will argue exactly as much as his suffering demands, which is everything.*

**THE FATHER.** All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

*Surrendering the philosophical argument, he retreats to the scene — the only ground he can still claim as his own.*

**THE MANAGER.** If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

*She turns the Manager's own earlier constraint against him, defending the sprawl of their reality with his words.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. [*Indicating Father.*] You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

*Compressing the family's diffuse suffering into stageable units, he makes the Boy's wandering the first casualty of theatrical convenience.*

**THE MANAGER.** Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

*Consumes, wastes — the clinical precision insists his deterioration is literal fact, not metaphor, and she will not let it be softened.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

*He begins tentatively to visualise the stage picture, sliding from arbitrator to director without noticing the crossing.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing in the garden... one in the house, and the other in the garden: isn't that it?

*The garden and the child are the one moment of unguarded tenderness she allows herself; it makes the coming loss unbearable.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless in the garden, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep beside her — I, do you understand? — carrying everything I carried, next to her, with her folding me in her loving little arms. In the garden, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

*Moving the Boy-chair himself, he crosses the point of no return — from judging the Characters to staging them, audience becoming accomplice.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well then, we'll have it in the garden. Everything shall happen in the garden — we'll group the other scenes there. *[Calls a Stage Hand.]* A backcloth with trees, and something to do as a fountain basin. Good — you've fixed it up. *[To Step-Daughter.]* This is just to give an idea, of course. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander about here in the garden, hiding behind the trees. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. *[To the Boy.]* Come forward a little. Let's try it. It's a nice business, this lad. What's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. *[He stands. He picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage. This is the pivot of his arc: until this gesture he has been the audience, watching from a remove. From this gesture forward he is the audience's complicity made physical. He places the Boy-chair behind the fountain basin, where it is partly hidden by the rim. The audience must read the move land.]* Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

*The Son's presence is her practical excuse, but the real aim is exposure; she knows his silence is its own kind of performance.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... *[Indicates the Son.]* You must send him away first.

*Eagerness to leave is the trap he springs on himself — the readiness to go is precisely what he cannot act on.*

**THE SON** *[jumping up]*. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

*Theatrical instinct stops him before thought does: a missing character is a broken scene, whatever his personal rights.*

**THE MANAGER** *[at once stopping him]*. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

*The Mother gets up alarmed and terrified at the thought that he is really about to go away. Instinctively she lifts her arms to prevent him, without, however, leaving her seat.*

*Genuine panic beneath the dignity — he is discovering his own captivity in real time, and it terrifies him.*

**THE SON** *[to Manager who stops him]*. I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

*Naming the connection is the first step to staging it; the question is not curious, it is coercive.*

**THE MANAGER.** What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

*Cold certainty more devastating than any argument: she has studied him, and knows his departure is impossible.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[calmly — she knows him]*. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

*He weaponises the plot against his own child, reducing the scene with the Mother to a theatrical obligation delivered without warmth.*

**THE FATHER.** He has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

*Stillness arrives in place of sullenness — not defiance but a stripped dignity, the body's final refusal when words have run out.*

**THE SON** *[the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives]*. I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. *[To the Manager.]* Let me go.

*With cold pleasure she demonstrates that the family's bonds are gravitational, not chosen — the Manager watches a trap close that he did not set.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[going over to the Manager]*. Allow me? *[Puts down the Manager's arm.]* Well, go on then — go away. *[The Son looks at her with contempt and hatred. She laughs.]* You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, supporting that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose only son he is. *[To the Mother.]* Come on, mother, come along! *[To Manager.]* You see, she was getting up to keep him back. You can imagine how little she wants to show your actors what she really feels — but so eager is she to get near him that... There, you see? She is willing to act her part.

*He accepts imprisonment but withholds consent, preserving the last scrap of autonomy even though it changes nothing at all.*

**THE SON** *[trapped now — and knowing it]*. No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

*Paternal authority has collapsed so completely he must borrow institutional power to enforce what he can no longer command himself.*

**THE FATHER** [to *Manager* excitedly]. You can force him, sir.

*Absolute and unadorned — he will not grant Manager, Father, or theatre itself the power to compel him.*

**THE SON.** Nobody can force me.

*A bluff and a horror at once; the play is about to test whether that claim can survive contact with the Son's contempt.*

**THE FATHER.** I can.

### PART III — THE FOUNTAIN

*She wrests control of the staging from the Manager, carrying the Child to the fountain herself — the urgency of someone who knows exactly how this ends.*

**THE STEP-DAUGHTER.** Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain... [Lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it to the fountain.]

*Approving blocking he does not understand, he files catastrophe under staging problems and moves efficiently on.*

**THE MANAGER.** Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

*The **Second Lady Lead** and the **Juvenile Lead** at this point separate themselves from the group of **Actors**. One watches the **Mother** attentively; the other moves about studying the movements and manner of the **Son** whom he will have to act.*

*Correcting the geography is the Son's way of refusing the emotional exposure entirely; factual accuracy is his last line of defence.*

**THE SON** [to *Manager*]. What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. [Indicates the **Mother**.] Ask her how it was!

*Her brevity is not rhetoric but rupture — a wound reopening, incapable of argument.*

**THE MOTHER.** Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

*Insisting on the room over the garden is a territorial act: the garden belongs to theatre, the room belonged to him.*

**THE SON.** Into *my* room. Do you understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

*Dismissing truth for grouping, he shows theatre's quiet violence — reality must be shaped to fit the frame.*

**THE MANAGER.** It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

*Not curious — threatening; he feels his selfhood being measured and will not stand still for it.*

**THE SON** [observing the **Juvenile Lead** studying him]. What do you want?

*Innocent as the denial is, it only deepens the wound: being watched without malice is somehow worse than being judged.*

**PLAYER 3.** Nothing! I was just looking at you.

*He reads the actress's attention as predatory mimicry, collapsing the distance between imitation and violation.*

**THE SON** [turning towards the **Second Lady Lead**]. Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! [Indicating the **Mother**.]

*Cheerful and completely oblivious, he mistakes the Son's horror for ingratitude and the actors' surveillance for generosity.*

**THE MANAGER.** Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

*The cry he has swallowed all night — to be staged is to live before a mirror that hands your face back deformed; the unbearable thing is being watched while you become yourself.*

**THE SON** [the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself]. Yes — but haven't you yet seen that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? One that doesn't simply hold your face, but throws it back at you — twisted into a grimace.

*Agreement here is tactics — he validates the Son's anguish to neutralise the Son's resistance to re-enactment.*

**THE FATHER.** That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

*He moves the actors not out of empathy but craft; he has finally found a blocking note he can execute.*

**THE MANAGER** [to *Second Lady Lead* and *Juvenile Lead*]. He's right! Move away from them!

*Flat withdrawal, not dramatic exit — negation is the only act of autonomy the Son has left.*

**THE SON.** Do as you like. I'm out of this!

*He silences the Son and pivots to the Mother with professional briskness, treating her pain as exposition to be extracted.*

**THE MANAGER.** Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! [To *Mother*.] You were saying you had entered...

*The hand at her chest is the speech beneath the speech; her body holds what words can barely begin.*

**THE MOTHER.** Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. [A hand at her chest, briefly.] But the moment he saw me...

*Self-protective repetition: if he insists nothing happened often enough, perhaps the guilt of doing nothing will dissolve.*

**THE SON.** Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

*She validates his version against herself — habitual self-erasure offering absolution he has not earned or asked for.*

**THE MOTHER.** It's true, true. That's how it was.

*He presses for the scene not because it matters emotionally but because the plot requires it; he is filling a structural gap.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

*Heartbreaking in its smallness — she needs only a crack, a moment, to pour out what she has carried for years.*

**THE MOTHER.** I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here. [Her hand at her chest.]

*His rage at the Son is also guilt redirected: he cannot bear what his own decisions have cost the Mother he claims to protect.*

**THE FATHER** [going to *Son* in a great rage]. You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

*Two words, flat affect — refusal so total it has passed through anger into something colder and more final.*

**THE SON** [flat]. I do nothing.

*When philosophy fails, he falls back on the bodily force he usually dresses as reason, shaking what words could not move.*

**THE FATHER** [taking hold of him and shaking him]. For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

*The counter-grip externalises the internal war: the Son refuses to be shaken into feeling, into someone else's story.*

**THE SON** [taking hold of the *Father*]. No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... [General agitation.]

*The **Mother**, frightened, tries to separate them.*

*Not asking for peace — trying to keep her hands on what little remains; the plea is wordless and desperate.*

**THE MOTHER** [both hands on the *Child-bundle*, gripping it]. Please! please!

*Holding on past persuasion, the grip itself says what he cannot: he needs the scene performed to justify his own suffering.*

**THE FATHER** [not leaving hold of the *Son*]. You've got to obey, do you hear?

*His refusal finds its ground — not stubbornness but shame, and a strange loyalty: even the author who made them flinched from this, and the Son will hold that line.*

**THE SON** [the voice cracking but the body refusing the cry]. What does it mean — this madness you've got? [They separate.] Have you no decency — that you would show the whole world our shame? I won't do it. I won't. The author who made us could not bear to stage this. Neither will I.

*Genuinely confused, unable to process the Son's logic: his world has no room for unwilling characters.*

**THE MANAGER.** Man alive! You came here...

*Pointing at the Father, he performs the one act he permits himself — attribution of blame, testimony that costs him nothing staged.*

**THE SON** [indicating *Father*]. He did! I didn't!

*Unanswerable and he knows it: presence itself has become a trap the Son cannot argue his way out of.*

**THE MANAGER.** Aren't you here now?

*A legal brief disguised as accusation — he distinguishes fact from fiction to delegitimise everything the Father has performed as truth.*

**THE SON.** It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

*Procedural sequence is his tool: forcing the Son to narrate what he fled, testimony extracted by dramatic necessity.*

**THE MANAGER.** Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

*His single-sentence answer turns the old silence into a moral position; he avoided a scene then and is still trying to now.*

**THE SON.** Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

*The neutral prompt exploits narrative momentum, keeping the Son talking against his every instinct to stop.*

**THE MANAGER.** And then what did you do?

*The hesitation and gloom mean he has arrived at the memory he cannot refuse — the garden walk is the last step before horror.*

**THE SON.** Nothing... walking in the garden... [Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]

*Gentleness here is almost predatory: he senses the reserve conceals something enormous and leans in like a man hunting the climax.*

**THE MANAGER** [coming closer to him, interested by his extraordinary reserve]. Well, well... walking in the garden...

*'Horrible' is aimed at himself — he is about to be forced to witness, again, what he could not prevent.*

**THE SON** [exasperated]. Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! [The *Mother's* arms are empty — the *Child-bundle* is no longer in them, and she is the first in the room to feel its absence. Her hands close on nothing. She trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain before anyone has said why.]

*Three words, rising dread — he has finally understood, and the question carries the entire weight of what the fountain means.*

**THE MANAGER** [slowly observing the glance and turning towards the *Son* with increasing apprehension]. The baby?

*The barest possible statement: he will not dramatise the drowning, but cannot withhold it; geography becomes elegy.*

**THE SON.** There in the fountain...

*Tender pity is also self-distancing — pointing at her grief draws attention away from his own failure to prevent it.*

**THE FATHER** [pointing with tender pity to the *Mother*]. She was following him at the moment...

*No longer directing, he is dreading the answer; his 'and then you' is the audience's held breath made audible.*

**THE MANAGER** [to the *Son* anxiously]. And then you...

*The stage lights drop slowly, breath by breath, beneath the Son's narration. By the end of it, only the fountain's pale-blue interior and the bare bulb above the Manager's table remain. The Boy-chair is silhouetted behind the basin.*

*Surrendering the story at last, he gives the room the image that has lived behind every refusal all evening: the Boy watching his sister drown.*

**THE SON** [the only continuous sentence he gives the room; he tells it because he cannot keep it inside any longer]. I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that stopped me where I stood. The boy. Standing stock still. With a look on his face I will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. [The *Step-Daughter* bends over the basin and lowers the *Child-bundle* into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.] Then... [The fountain light holds for ten seconds on the silhouette of the Boy-chair behind the basin — the Boy watching. Then full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is.]

Lights snap back up at the cry that follows. The Boy is never seen dead — only the silhouette before, and the sound. What remains is the family, the company, the Manager, and the silence the audience has just been made to look into.

The **Mother** does not cry out at once. She goes first to the basin and reaches down for the **Child-bundle** in the water; then, hearing the **Players** take up the **Boy-chair** behind her, she turns and reaches for that too. Her arms cannot hold both. The veil stays down over her face — she never lifts it herself, not even now. Only then does the sound come out of her.

Every layer of performance stripped away — raw, ancient, maternal; the character and the wound are finally indistinguishable.

**THE MOTHER.** My son! My son! [Then amid the cries and exclamations one hears her voice.] Help! Help!

Half practical, half terrified, he is still trying to locate himself on the line between fiction and fact.

**THE MANAGER** [pushing the **Players** aside while they lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible]. Is he really wounded?

They perform the news of death before they have processed it themselves — fact and theatre arriving simultaneously.

**PLAYER 1 & PLAYER 3.** He's dead! dead!

Clinging to pretence as a life raft, the reassurance is for themselves as much as anyone else in the room.

**PLAYER 2.** No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

His first uncontrolled moment: 'pretence' is the one wound no amount of philosophy can absorb.

**THE FATHER** [with a terrible cry]. Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

Not a decision but a collapse — he leaves because he no longer knows what theatre is for.

**THE MANAGER** [no commentary, no irony]. Pretence? Reality? [He looks at the empty Boy-chair.] To hell with it all. [He turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre.]